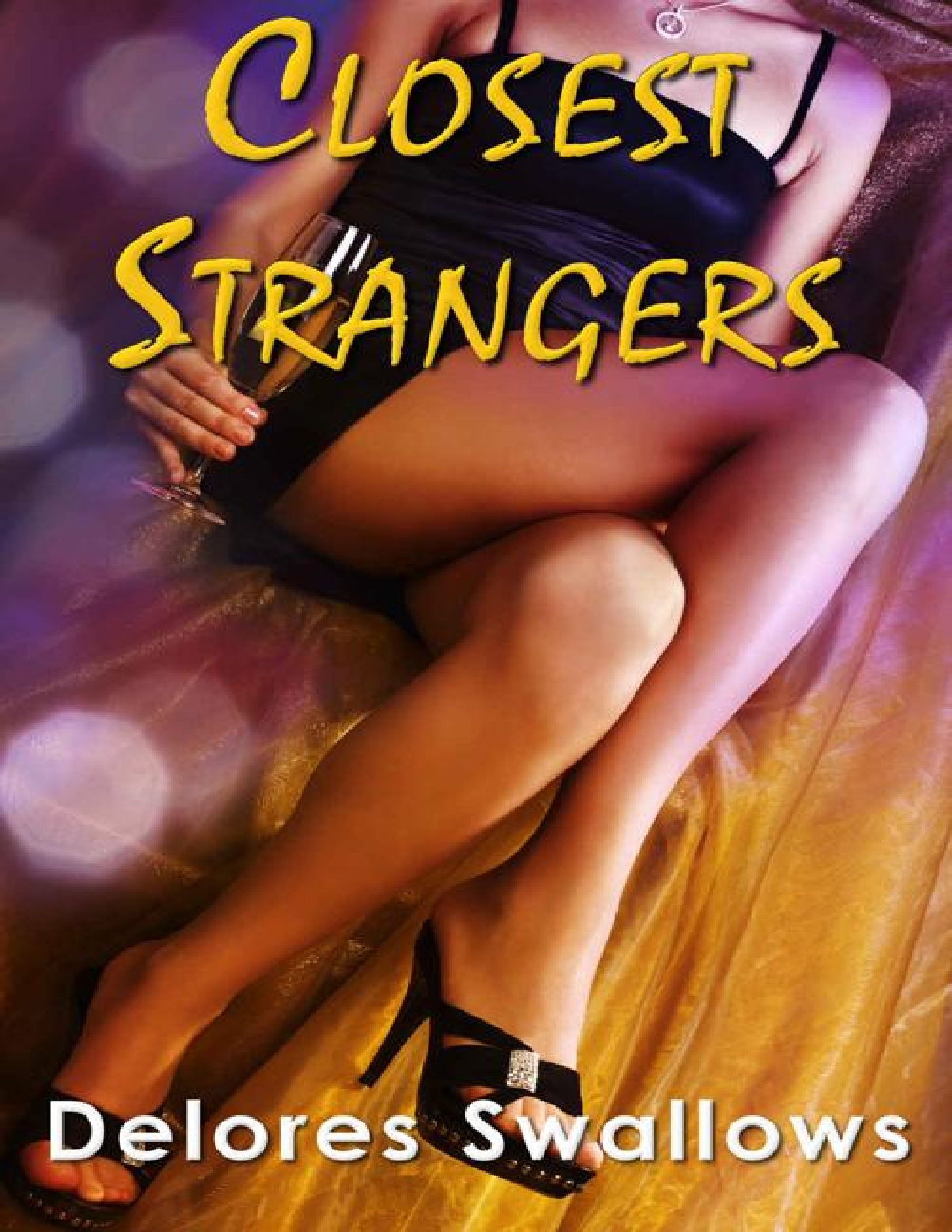


A woman with long blonde hair is sitting on a bright yellow, draped fabric. She is wearing a black, sleeveless, form-fitting dress and black high-heeled sandals with a silver buckle. She is holding a clear glass in her right hand. The background is a soft, out-of-focus purple and blue light. The title "CLOSEST STRANGERS" is written in large, yellow, stylized letters across the top of the image.

CLOSEST STRANGERS

Delores Swallows

Closest Strangers

An Erotic Thriller

by Delores Swallows

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Content Advisory: This book is intended for mature audiences and contains explicit sexual activity.

Closest Strangers

When Mark receives a letter from his girlfriend asking for help, he assumes she's having trouble from an ex-boyfriend.

He hurries to Bristol to help her out, only to find that she's been a voluntary participant in the seedy goings-on of a criminal underworld. But now she's apparently upset a psychotic gangster who becomes convinced Mark's part of a plan to disrupt his business.

Mark getting dragged into the fray is bad enough, but he soon discovers it's not only himself that's been drawn into the mess...

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Chapter One

It was a dreary Saturday afternoon and Mark worked alone in the smallest bedroom of a semi-detached house in a quiet cul-de-sac in Wistaston. He was securing pine shelves to metal brackets he'd already fitted to the wall. The live football commentary on the radio drowned out the sound of the phone ringing downstairs. His landlady Lauren was out shopping, so the call went unanswered.

The caller didn't leave a message.

* * * *

One hundred and fifty miles to the south in Bath, Philippa slammed down the receiver in frustration. A middle-aged couple sitting at the other end of the bar looked up, startled. Philippa shrugged an apology to them and also to the man behind the bar. She left the small back-street pub and wandered out into the grey afternoon. Although it was only a little after three, the light was fading and the November evening would soon be upon her. She was frightened, and knew the longer she had to spend in this city, the worse her fear would get. She was also angry at herself. How could she have believed she'd have gotten away with this? What had she been thinking? And how the hell could she have been stupid enough to leave her mobile in Em's flat?

* * * *

In a bar called Moondust in Bristol, just a dozen miles from Bath, Mal Marsden was shouting into his mobile phone.

"I don't fucking-well know, do I? And I don't fucking-well care, either. Just find the bitch and bring her here." He stabbed at his iPhone and shook his head.

A handful of people were gathered around him by the bar. An attractive black woman moved closer and rubbed his back. Mal looked at her, closed his eyes and let out a sigh.

“Fucking unbelievable.”

Honey gave his shoulders a reassuring squeeze. “I’m sure you’ll get it sorted out, babe. You always do.”

Mal nodded, not completely convinced. “It’s the timing of it that’s winding me up. I just don’t need this now. I’ve no idea what she thinks she’s doing, but she’ll be fucking sorry when I get my hands on her.”

No one offered any words of encouragement, probably wary of his mood. He wasn’t surprised—he had a tendency to be a little volatile if people inadvertently said the wrong thing.

* * * *

Across the city in The Stargazer, Emily was working behind the bar when she saw Giff walk in. Since they both worked for the same person they were theoretically colleagues, but Emily didn’t like him. He was a complete waste of carbon. He’d been a bouncer in one of Mal’s clubs when she started, and over the years he’d bullied his way up to being Mal’s personal hired muscle.

She waited patiently while Giff looked her up and down, obviously enjoying her discomfort. He was handsome enough and spent a lot of time in the gym, so his body was well toned. Emily knew a lot of the other girls liked him, but she hated his attitude—to women in general, and to her in particular.

“So,” he said, leaning over the bar to get a look at her legs. “How come Fizz went home this morning? It seems like a long way to come for just one night. Did she get fed up of all the carpet-munching?”

Emily didn’t rise to the bait.

Giff had been through most of the barmaids in the four bars Mal owned, and rumour had it he’d been through a high proportion of the female customers as well. Emily had never given him the time of day, so he’d convinced himself she must be a lesbian.

She tried to sound matter-of-fact. “She has a party back home in Cheshire to get to. I knew she was only coming down for one night.”

Giff sucked in his cheeks, checked out Emily’s chest, then pushed himself away from the bar. “Well, if she does call you, tell her that Mal wants to see her. Immediately.”

“Okay. Do you know what it’s about?”

He smiled without a trace of humour. “Seems like she’s helped herself to something she shouldn’t have.” He walked to the door, and then turned round. “By the way, if Fizz’s gone back north for a party, she must have walked. Her car’s been wheel-clamped at the university campus in Bath.”

Emily saw him watching her face, trying to gauge her reaction to this news. She tried to maintain a neutral expression until he turned and let the door shut behind him. She waited a few minutes to make sure he wasn’t coming back, then retrieved her phone from her handbag and called Philippa’s mobile. After several rings it switched to voice-mail. She didn’t leave a message.

* * * *

A knock on the bedroom door made Mark look up as Lauren’s head popped round the door. She was still wearing her coat and leather gloves, her cheeks red from the cold. Her long light-brown hair was tucked inside the scarf around her neck.

“Hi.” She walked over to the shelves.

Mark shuffled back on his knees a little to let her inspect them.

“They look great.” She ran her hand across one, pushing down on it slightly.

“Don’t worry, they’re not going to fall down as soon as you put your stuff on them.”

“I was just seeing how firm they were. There’s a lot of weight in books, you know.”

“What you mean is, you’re questioning my DIY skills.”

Lauren smiled as she walked towards the door. “Oh, I don’t doubt your DIY skills at all. What you do in the privacy of your room is your own business. I just want to know if these shelves will hold all my books.”

Mark threw a rawl-plug at her as she disappeared around the door.

When she came back in, she’d removed her coat and gloves and was rubbing her hands together. “Fancy a coffee?”

Mark smiled and nodded.

While Lauren went downstairs to the kitchen, he fixed the final shelf in place. Five minutes later he was tidying away his tools, and she returned with two steaming mugs. Lauren sat on the chair by the desk, Mark on the floor. She looked round at her new study.

“It’ll be great to get all my stuff out of boxes and onto shelves. I’ve wanted this room sorted for ages. Thank you.”

“No problem.”

Mark enjoyed the comfortable silence in which they sipped their coffee—it came naturally now they’d known each other seven years. They’d met through a mutual friend in their early twenties and remained just friends for the first year or so. Then they’d become romantically involved, and moved in together shortly afterwards. They’d shared a flat for three years, and Mark thought everything was perfect. They had good jobs, took exotic holidays, and had a great sex-life. Just as he was thinking of suggesting they both give up their jobs and travel for a couple of years, Lauren got promoted and suddenly wanted stability. The sort of stability that comes with a diamond ring, shortly followed by a day in church and another ring. She’d seen his reluctance and they’d parted on good terms.

Two and a half years later, he’d met her in the local supermarket. He’d only been back in the country a few weeks, and they went for a drink to catch up. Mark had returned to his old job in the IT department after travels which had taken him to China, Thailand, Indonesia, New Zealand, Australia, and the States. During that time, Lauren had met someone else—in fact, in less than 12 months she’d met, married and left someone named Colin. Financially she was in trouble because she’d had to buy his half of their house and was struggling with the repayments so they’d come to an arrangement. Mark rented a spare room, helping Lauren to meet the

mortgage repayments. They'd co-existed like this for almost a year, and the arrangement was working well for both of them.

Lauren broke the silence. "Are you in or out tonight?"

"Er, I was going to be in, but if you want I can go out." Mark liked to pretend he was an adult by exercising discretion when Lauren had a man around.

"No, I've no plans. I was going to suggest making you dinner, as a thank you for the shelves."

The idea of a nice dinner without having to cook it himself appealed to him. "That'd be nice. I'm playing squash with Mick at six, but I should be back here for about half-seven. Is that OK?"

"Fine." Lauren took the cups down to the kitchen.

Ten minutes later he walked downstairs with his coat on and his kit-bag in his hand. As he picked up his keys from the shelf in the hall, Lauren shouted to him from the lounge. Mark popped his head into the room.

"There was a phone call while I was out this afternoon, but they didn't leave a message. It was a 01225 number—any ideas?"

"That's the code for Bath. It'd probably have been Philippa, but I'm not sure why she didn't use her mobile."

"Shouldn't you try and call her?"

Mark looked at his watch and shook his head. "Not got time."

"And they say romance is dead."

Mark grinned. "You know what they also say, *treat 'em mean, keep 'em keen.*"

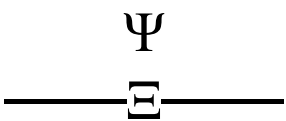
"It's men like you who turn women to lesbianism."

Mark made a show of putting his bag down and leaning on the wall by the front door. "Well, if you feel the need to describe any of your experiences, I could always be a bit late for squash."

"Go, you pervert. And if Philippa calls back, I'll tell her you're out with another woman."

Mark smiled and left.





Chapter Two

Philippa punched in her pin at the ATM, stealing glances over her shoulder as she waited for the cash. Finding her car clamped had been a shock and she'd hurried away without thinking to check if anyone was hanging around waiting for her, which of course meant someone could be following her. She withdrew the full limit of three hundred pounds.

She realised it was probably a paranoid reaction, but Mal had all sorts of contacts and she feared he could trace her if she tried to use her bank or credit cards. At least this way there'd only be one transaction with the bank itself. She doubted even *he* could get Barclays to reveal a simple withdrawal—however close to the daily limit.

If Philippa couldn't contact Mark to drive down and pick her up, she may have to buy a train ticket. She'd rather do that with cash. She was sure Mal had disabled her car because wheel-clamping didn't usually happen on the campus car-park. So Mal knew she'd now have to find another way of leaving and she was sure he'd have someone looking out for her at the station. She tried to think of another way of getting back home.

One option was to flash a bit of leg to a lorry driver. Philippa was so scared that she'd happily bounce up and down on a lorry driver's cock for an hour if he promised to get her back to Cheshire safely. But just standing by a busy road waiting for a ride seemed like too much of a risk. Mal had his finger on the pulse of this whole area, knowing way too many people—from taxi drivers to policemen. For someone who spent so much of his life breaking the law, Mal Marsden had many friends in both high and low places.

She decided to get a room in a guest house and to keep trying to contact Mark. She walked down Crescent Gardens, where she'd stayed with her mother four years ago when they attended the university's open day. They'd stayed in another guest house on the same street the following year, when her brother Jason had decided to study at Bath Uni, too. She forced

herself not to think about what had happened to her family since then. She was in enough trouble without going through all that again.

At the end of the street there was a convenience store. She picked up toothbrush, toothpaste, a note pad and a pack of envelopes. She already had some stamps in her purse. Another product caught her eye, and after a moment's hesitation she added it to her basket, paid for the items and left. Outside, she wrote a short note:

Mark

I'm in trouble. Mal Marsden is after me. Please look after this key for me until I see you.

If you haven't heard from me by the time you get this letter, please go to a pub called The Stargazer in Bristol, and ask for Emily. She'll explain.

Pxx

Philippa put the note into the envelope, added the small silver key, affixed a stamp and dropped it into the post-box outside the shop.

Twenty minutes later, she paid fifty pounds in cash to a middle-aged lady for bed and breakfast. Her room was clean and modestly furnished. She walked into the bathroom and ran a bath. She used the phone to try Mark's number, and again the call went unanswered. She didn't leave a message because she wasn't sure she could get through the message without bursting into tears. She stripped off her clothes and took her recent purchases into the bathroom. She looked at her own reflection in the mirror until the steam condensed on the cold surface. As she lowered herself into the very hot water, the gravity of her situation finally overcame her. Philippa started to cry.

* * * *

When Mark walked into the kitchen, Lauren was slicing mushrooms and peppers.

She looked up at him and smiled. “Ready to eat in ten minutes?”

Mark nodded, looking into the pan of bubbling chicken curry. It smelt wonderful. He motioned to the bag in his hand. “I’ll just stick this upstairs, and add my sweaty shirt and shorts to your pile of lacy underwear in the linen basket.”

“Don’t even think about it! Put them straight into the washer. I don’t want my expensive lingerie to smell like a sumo wrestler’s jock-strap.”

He feigned a hurt look but stuck his dirty kit and towel in the washer before taking his bag to his room. He returned downstairs just as Lauren was opening a bottle of Australian merlot. Mark helped himself to a cold beer.

“Worked up a thirst, have we?” she teased.

He frowned at her. Lauren knew Mick was a good squash player. Mark had never beaten him—never even taken a game off him. He shrugged as he swigged on his beer. “You could say that. Nine-three; nine-four; nine-one. If you’re interested.”

“I’m not.” Lauren took the bottle of wine and two glasses into the lounge. Mark followed her. She poured herself some wine and left the bottle next to Mark’s empty glass. “Oh, there was another phone call for you.”

Mark waited. “And?”

“I was in the shower. It stopped ringing before I got halfway down the stairs.”

“So how do you know it was for me?”

“Well I assume it was your young lady again. It was the same code, but I think it was a different number than last time.”

Mark shook his head. He couldn’t understand why Philippa wouldn’t be using her mobile. Low battery, maybe? It’d be typical of her to go away for the weekend and forget to take her charger.

“So,” Lauren asked. “Are you two getting serious?”

Mark had a mouthful of beer so couldn’t answer straight away. He shook his head, swallowed. “Not really. Don’t get me wrong—she’s nice, and I like her. But it’s just...”

“Lust.”

Mark smiled. “No. Yes. But she’s—”

“Easy?”

“No.” Mark hesitated, reconsidered. “Actually, yeah. But that’s not what I was going to say. She’s very—”

“Young.”

Mark knew Lauren was teasing, but she hit the nail on the head every time. “Yes, she’s young. And she’s enjoying being young. She still goes back to visit her old university crowd every other weekend. I think she had quite a hectic social life as a student and she’s reluctant to give it up.” Mark took another swig of his beer. “Besides, I don’t want her to give it up. But now I’ve hit thirty, I really can’t be arsed with night-clubbing anymore.”

Lauren smiled mischievously. “Finding it hard to keep up with someone almost ten years younger, are we?”

“Well *you* might be, but I’m having no problems, thanks.” Mark became a little more serious, and completely honest. “Having said that, I wouldn’t be surprised if one of the things pulling her back to Bath every weekend was another man.”

“Really?” Lauren looked surprised. “Doesn’t that bother you?”

He shook his head. “Not really, no. Do you think I’m finally growing up?”

“God, I hope so. But I doubt it.” She left to serve up their food, and Mark checked the paper to see what was on television.

* * * *

Philippa wiped the steam from the bathroom mirror and stared at her reflection. It was like looking at a stranger. Her face was pale, except for the redness around her eyes from crying. Her usually-blond hair, still wet and clinging to her face, was now a dark brown. Hopefully this simple change would improve her chances of getting out of the area.

She put on knickers and t-shirt and sat on the bed with the pad she’d bought earlier, writing down a list of her options. When she had ten listed,

she wrote each option as a heading on a new page and drew a vertical line down each to make plus and minus columns. Her options included going back to Mal and apologising, continue phoning Mark in the hope he'd drop everything and come and get her, catching a train, and hiring a car. One heading simply read 'Emily', but Philippa didn't even bother with pros and cons on that one. It wasn't fair to get Em involved in any of this. Not only would Em lose her job, but she could also end up in real physical danger.

Another idea that never made the list was calling her parents. Philippa hadn't seen them since Jason's funeral, and she had no intention of contacting them now. As she looked down at the pad on her knee, her eyes wandered over the birthmark on her wrist. She'd inherited it from her dad—he'd told her as a child it was a sign that meant she was special. She remembered that Jason'd had one on his upper thigh.

For the next two hours Philippa thought about each possibility, wishing she had a better plan than just picking the piece of paper with the fewest 'minus' comments on it.

* * * *

Mal sat at the desk in his first floor office sipping Caol Ila, a malt whiskey he'd been introduced to during a trip to the Highlands a few years back. He'd just finalised the arrangements for tomorrow's south coast trip and was a little apprehensive. Mal was a fairly big fish in a medium sized pond, but he was trying to better himself. In just over fourteen hours he'd be meeting Ray Lacey—a big fish wherever he chose to swim.

Mal looked up at the gentle knock on the door. Honey peered round the edge and he watched as she glided across the room. She was without doubt the most stunning woman he'd ever seen. The result of a night of passion between a Kenyan diplomat and a Czech catering assistant, Honey ended up blessed with perfect features; coffee-coloured skin, a heart-shaped face with prominent cheekbones, almond eyes, and full lips. Her statuesque body moved with grace; her ebony eyes sparkled with intelligence. He'd seen her one evening three years ago during a visit to London and, just two

hours after offering to buy her a drink, he'd convinced her to move to Bristol.

"Hey babe," she purred. "How's it going?"

He looked at his watch. It was a little before eleven. On a normal night they'd be busy downstairs, helping the patrons to relax and enjoy their evening, but he was in no mood for company. Although he'd never admit it to anyone, he was extremely nervous about tomorrow's meeting. A lot rested on the outcome; not just the financial aspect, but respect.

"Come on," he said. "I suppose we should be downstairs, mixing with the paying public."

* * * *

Lauren and Mark had eaten, drunk a bottle of wine, watched the film and chatted. Then they'd finished another bottle of wine and fallen asleep together on the settee, her head on Mark's shoulder, and his head resting against hers. Lauren woke up first and looked at the clock. It was almost one in the morning. She prodded Mark in the ribs.

"God, you're lousy company. You were so boring I dropped off."

"Bollocks. I fell asleep first. You're an accountant, don't forget. You need an A-level in *Dull* just to get an interview."

They carried on bickering like an old married couple as Lauren carried the glasses into the kitchen, and he turned off the television and lights.

"Well, I've had some exciting evenings on that couch with a lot of men who found me pretty stimulating company," she said as they made their way up the stairs.

"When you say 'stimulating', d'you mean they were just glad you'd still got a pulse?" Mark knew that a widowed gentleman in his fifties had recently asked Lauren out to dinner, but she'd declined the offer.

"Oh! Very funny."

By now he'd joined her on the landing. "Well, I thought so,"

“Let me tell you, the only pulse that mattered was theirs. And I can assure you the blood was flowing healthily to *all* the right places.”

Mark made a face like he didn't feel well. “Are you trying to make my chicken curry come back up?”

“Ha ha ha. You're so funny. Yes, you are. Really.”

Mark was smiling to himself as Lauren went into the bathroom and locked the door. He went into his room to remove his jeans and shirt. When he heard her come out of the bathroom he went to brush his teeth. She was still on the landing wearing a long sleep-shirt when he emerged from his bedroom wearing just his boxer shorts.

Lauren covered her eyes with a hand. “*Now* who's trying to make someone bring up their curry?”

Mark took her head in his hands and landed a light kiss on top. “Thanks for dinner. Now stop talking before you make my ears fall off.”

Lauren smiled at him, and went into her room, and Mark went into the bathroom.

* * * *

The last of the bar staff had left Moondust, and Mal was finishing off the remainder of his whisky. Honey turned off the lights behind the bar and went upstairs to their living quarters. She slipped off her shoes, cleaned her teeth and removed her make-up in the bathroom. When she came out, Mal was sitting on the bed untying his shoelaces. Honey could sense his mood, and it frightened her a little.

She was aware of him watching her as she slipped off her dress, his reflection showing in the mirror on her dressing table. She turned towards him and held eye contact as she unhooked her bra. Mal unbuttoned his shirt. His eyes wandered down to take in her body. She slid into bed, and Mal went into the bathroom. He left the door open while he peed, and didn't bother to wash his hands afterwards. Back in the bedroom, he removed his trousers and underpants. He was small and wiry, but he exuded strength and confidence. His black hair was receding slightly, and he kept it cropped

short. His face had a constant five o'clock shadow even immediately after a shave, which gave him the look of a gangster from the thirties.

He got into bed and turned off the table light. In the dark, Honey could hear his breathing. His anger seemed to be smouldering just beneath the surface. She knew from experience that the only way either of them would get any sleep would be if he could burn off all his pent up energy. What Mal needed right now was either to fight or fuck, and she was only equipped to do one of those things with any conviction.

Honey was lying on her stomach, Mal on his back. She slid her hand onto his chest. He stroked her arm for a few seconds, and then pulled her on top of him. He kissed her roughly, scratching her face with his stubble, biting her lips. His breath smelt of whisky and stale cigarettes. His hands slid down her back and kneaded her buttocks, pulling her against him. She felt his cock stiffening through the thin material of her knickers. Suddenly, Mal put his hands on her shoulders and pushed her downwards. As her head got beneath the covers, Honey let out a sigh of relief. She knew that fucking Mal in this mood often resulted in bite marks on her shoulders and finger-bruises on her backside. This way, the worst she could expect was getting her hair pulled.

There would be no teasing tonight. No slow climb of the juices, where she expertly licked, sucked and stroked him for an hour, taking him in stages to the ultimate release. This was not that sort of situation. Honey licked her lips and filled her mouth with saliva. She took the tip of his cock into her warm, wet mouth, feeling it grow a little more and become completely hard. Then she pushed her head down onto him until her face was against his pubic hair. She heard Mal let out a groan as his cock went deep into her throat. Honey cupped his balls with her hand and gently prodded the opening of his anus with a finger, and in less than thirty seconds she had Mal on the brink of orgasm. She squeezed his balls tighter and pushed a little further into his arse. Mal bucked up and down, pulling her head onto him and fucking her mouth. The first spurt hit the back of her throat; the subsequent ones showered the inside of her mouth. Her tongue was relentless, licking over and around the sensitive head of his cock as he was coming. Still caressing his balls, Honey used her other hand to wank the base of his shaft, moving up and down with short, twisting motions. Mal

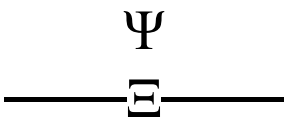
cried out, and rewarded her with another jet of his cum, and an even tighter grip on her hair.

Mal slowed his thrusting, and finally stopped. Honey moved up the bed a little and laid her head against his chest, listening to his heartbeat as it slowed to a normal rate.

“Mal,” she whispered.

When he didn’t reply, she realised he was asleep.





Chapter Three

Philippa woke with a start. A knock sounded on the door. She jumped out of bed, convinced Mal had tracked her down. She realised she was sobbing; her heart was beating so fast she worried she might actually faint. Looking around the room, she knew there was nowhere for her to run. In films, the heroine always managed to sneak down a fire escape, or climb from one balcony to another. Philippa looked out of the window. No balcony. No fire escape. Just a straight drop to a small, paved garden. Another knock on the door, but this one followed by a woman's voice. Philippa couldn't hear what she was saying, but the fact it was a woman helped her to calm down. She opened the door a few inches. The lady who owned the guest-house smiled at her.

"I'm sorry to disturb you, love. I just thought I'd see if you were wanting any breakfast. We stop serving at ten."

"Oh, right. Yes, please. What time is it now?"

"It's almost a quarter past."

"Nine?"

"Ten."

Philippa's heart sank. She'd spent most of the night crying and now she'd overslept, missing the chance to phone Mark before he went to his Sunday morning five-a-side. He played even when they'd spent the Saturday night together, which was a bone of contention with her.

"Are you alright, dear?"

Philippa saw concern in the landlady's face. She realised what a state she must look—her eyes must be bloodshot and swollen.

"I'm fine, thank you. I just didn't sleep too well, that's all."

"And whatever happened to your lovely blonde hair?"

Philippa had forgotten about applying the dye. She tried to smile. "Oh, I just fancied a change."

“Well, I’ll keep the cooker on if you’re coming down,” the landlady said, moving towards the stairs.

“Thank you. I won’t be long.” Less than five minutes later, she made her way to the dining room. The only other guests were an elderly couple sharing a pot of tea and each reading a newspaper. They looked up and smiled at her when she came in, and the landlady herself came to take her order. Philippa wasn’t hungry but was determined to make herself eat something because this could turn out to be a very long day. She ordered orange juice, scrambled egg on toast, and black coffee.

Missing Mark was a major blow—she knew that his Sunday routine was football then go for a drink afterwards, which meant it’d be early afternoon before she had any chance of getting hold of him. Another bone of contention was his refusal to buy a mobile phone. He was the only person she knew who made a point of not having one. Philippa poured herself another cup of coffee and tried to come up with a plan that didn’t depend on Mark.

* * * *

Mal was showered, shaved, dressed and drinking coffee at the table when Honey wandered into the kitchen. She leaned down and kissed his cheek, then walked to the fridge. He watched her as she bent to reach a carton of grapefruit juice. She was wearing one of his shirts, and nothing else. Her feet were bare. The toe-nails were expertly painted, her skin slightly paler on the soles. She’d only fastened a couple of the buttons at the front of the shirt and he was getting glimpses of her dark-brown nipples every time she moved. If he had more time, he’d take her there and then on the kitchen table. It wouldn’t have been the first time.

Mal checked his watch. “Giff’s going to be here in a few minutes, so you’d better get dressed. If he sees you like that, he’ll be creaming in his jeans.”

Honey’s expression made it obvious she didn’t like to think about what went on inside Giff’s trousers.

Mal called Newfoundland Road station. After several rings his call was transferred.

“Good morning. I’m trying to get hold of DS Waltham.” He listened for a few seconds, thanked the person at the other end, then called an alternative number. “Donald, someone at the station seems to think today is your day off. Tell me they’re wrong.” He let out an impatient sigh. “No, you’re fucking not. You’re going to get out of bed, get your lazy arse down to your desk, and use all the resources available to you to help me get my property back.”

Mal slammed down the phone without bothering to listen to the detective’s reply. “Fucking tosser,” he muttered. “I don’t know who he thinks he’s dealing with. As if I care what time he was working ’til last night.”

Mal made another couple of calls then phoned Jimmy to suggest what he could be doing to help trace Philippa. Jimmy wasn’t the sharpest tool in the work shop, but he was always eager to please.

“You know—make a few calls to cab firms and ask about any fares involving women travelling on their own. She’ll probably go to the station seeing as her car’s useless to her.”

Giff arrived and waited by the door while Mal listened to Jimmy. Just then, Honey came through from the bedroom. She’d showered and dressed in a grey angora V-neck jumper with hipster jeans tucked into mid-calf length black leather boots. Mal saw Giff checking out her chest in the tight sweater but let it ride; he had enough hassle already without having Giff in a sulk all day.

If this was a normal day, he’d clear his schedule and sort Fizz’s disappearance out himself. But there was no way he could avoid attending his meeting today. Ray Lacey wouldn’t stand for that—particularly with the shipment from France due to arrive in the next couple of days.

* * * *

When Mark came back from football, Lauren was sitting in the lounge reading.

“Did you manage to get a kick of the ball, or did the young boys move too fast for you to catch?”

“Oh, I got the odd kick.” Mark smiled. “Which, incidentally, is exactly what you’ll get if you try any more wise-cracks.”

Lauren laughed. “Fancy a coffee?”

He shrugged, not sure he wanted to waste the good weather. “Well, it’s quite a nice day, so I was thinking of going out for lunch. Care to join me?”

Lauren’s face showed she liked the idea. “That’s an offer I can’t refuse.”

“Obviously I’ll probably demand favours on the drive back.”

“And that’s an offer I’ll definitely refuse.” She laughed, punching his arm as she walked past him on her way to put on some lipstick.

* * * *

Philippa decided she didn’t want to hang around until she could get hold of Mark. She would call a taxi and take it to a train station outside Bath, like Chippenham or Trowbridge. Then catch the first train, regardless of its destination. Once she was out of the area she could relax a little, and get another train to take her back up to Cheshire. Surely Mal wouldn’t have someone at those stations, too. Would he?

She borrowed a phone directory and took it up to her room, then booked a taxi from a Chippenham firm to pick her up in forty minutes’ time. She paced her room until she saw it pull up by the gate, then went downstairs, thanked the landlady and left.

The taxi’s radio had continuous chatter between the dispatcher and the various drivers. Philippa tried to listen to everything, terrified the dispatcher would say something like “*OK, take her back to Moondust.*” But nothing happened, and she chided herself for being too melodramatic. The driver attempted to make conversation, but she was too nervous to give more than one word answers. Eventually he stopped talking and the journey was completed in silence.

When they arrived at Chippenham, the station looked deserted. She was worried it was closed and wondered whether to ask the taxi driver if £300 was enough to cover his charge for driving her all the way to Cheshire. But then she saw people on the platform. There must be a train due soon, and no matter where it was going, she intended to be on it. Tipping the driver five pounds, she walked toward the ticket office.

* * * *

Giff drove the black Mercedes south on the A38 before joining the M5 towards Exeter. Mal's meeting was scheduled for noon, and they'd allowed themselves plenty of time to complete the 90-mile journey. Although Mal sat in the front alongside him, there was no conversation between them. Mal eventually broke the silence just as they approached Junction 29, where they were to leave the motorway.

"Did you type the address into this thing?" he asked, turning on the satellite navigation system.

Giff pressed a button and the screen immediately lit up, showing them where they were in relation to Exeter. He didn't have it on because he wouldn't need it until they got closer. He could navigate a motorway without being told what to do. He glanced over at Mal. "How's this going to go down?"

"What d'you mean?"

"Do you want me to stay in the room with you, or will it be just the two of you?"

Mal shrugged. "Let's see how he wants to do it."

Giff recognised this as a change from the norm. Things usually went however Mal wanted to do it. Nothing more was said until they pulled into the car park of the snooker club where Ray Lacey would be joining them in about twenty minutes' time.

* * * *

Lauren and Mark had driven west from Nantwich towards Wrexham, passing many small picturesque villages on the way. They stopped at a nice country pub overlooking the Peckforton Hills. Ten minutes later, they were sitting at a small table by the window, sipping their drinks and reading through the menu. Lauren settled on the lamb. She looked up to ask Mark if he'd made his mind up, then saw a couple of familiar faces—Dorothy and John, long-time friends of her parents—leaving their table and heading in their direction. She'd known them since she was a little girl, and although she was always pleased to see them, she felt a little awkward about meeting them today. She didn't want them to tell her parents they'd seen Lauren and Mark having lunch, because her mother would no doubt revert to the usual script—what a nice boy, you two seemed so happy, not like with that Colin. Lauren smiled as they approached.

“Hello, love,” said Dorothy. “I didn't know you two were back together.”

“We're not back together,” Lauren said quickly. “We're just friends now. But because it's such a nice day, we thought we'd have lunch out. That's all.”

Mark looked around as if to ensure nobody was listening, and then half whispered, “I think Lauren's hoping to get me drunk and then seduce me in a quiet lane on the drive back.”

John laughed and Dorothy looked a bit shocked. Lauren kicked Mark hard under the table.

“Don't listen to him, he's just teasing.” She tried for a smile, but it didn't quite come off.

“Oh, I'm sure he is,” assured Dorothy.

“I may well tease her all the way home,” Mark added, giving them his best Eric Idle wink.

Dorothy pulled a light jacket around her shoulders. “Well, it was lovely to see you both again.”

“Yes, you too,” said Lauren. As soon as they left she glared at Mark. “What the hell was that?”

“I was just being myself and making light of the situation!”

“You shouldn’t tell a lady in her sixties that the daughter of her best friend is going to try to get you drunk and shag you in the car.”

“I thought I put it a little less bluntly than that,” Mark said defensively.

“Not much.”

Mark put the menu aside with a grin. “You worry too much. Right, I’m going to have steak pie. What shall I order for you?”



Chapter Four

The next train was due to leave in thirty-five minutes, going to Swindon, then Oxford. Philippa was sure she could get a connecting train from Oxford to Crewe, or even Stoke. For the first time that weekend she started to relax a little. She sat down on an unoccupied bench to wait for the train. She considered calling Mark again from the phone box she'd seen on the station car park, but decided against it. She'd wait until she was in Oxford, because then she'd know the timings for the trains north and would be able to tell him when to pick her up, and where.

As she waited, Philippa reflected on how she'd felt yesterday as she walked down the street towards the guest house. A whole range of happy yet painful memories came flooding back. The first visit was over four years ago, when she'd been with her parents just before she'd started her degree. The following year they'd stayed on the same street when her brother Jason managed to get accepted at Bath Uni, too. Her parents had been so relieved when he'd got in at the same university because they felt having his big sister close by would help him adapt to moving away from home. Jason was always the shy one and struggled to make friends. Philippa, on the other hand, had always been the life and soul of the party.

So much had happened since then it seemed like a lifetime ago—almost as if it was just something she'd dreamt about rather than had actually happened. She wiped a tear from her cheek as she remembered the last time she'd seen her parents, standing by the side of Jason's grave as the vicar recited a prayer. She knew her parents blamed her for Jason's death. They'd never said it in so many words, but they didn't have to. The irony was they didn't have the slightest clue as to just how right they were.

An announcement over the railway station public address system broke into her thoughts. The distorted voice informed passengers waiting on platform two that the train was running approximately ten minutes late.

Philippa curled her fingers round the edge of the seat, determined to stay calm.

* * * *

Ray Lacey arrived at the snooker hall exactly on time, accompanied by two men wearing dark suits who stayed a couple of paces behind him as he walked toward the table where Mal was sitting. Mal stood up as they approached and shook Lacey's hand.

"Drink?" Mal asked.

Lacey shook his head. "I thought we could have a drink on our way to see Louis."

Mal tried not to show the surprise he felt. "I'm meeting him today?"

Lacey nodded. "I thought it best. Obviously you can't expect him to get into this without at least seeing who he's dealing with. Besides, I told him you wanted to meet up and see the stuff yourself."

"So we're going there now? To France?"

Lacey nodded again.

"I didn't bring my passport."

Before Lacey could answer, Mal realised how stupid he must have just sounded. There they were—in the middle of setting up a smuggling operation—and he was flapping because he didn't have his passport with him. He shook his head in apology.

As the men headed for the door, Lacey was still chortling to himself. "Fucking passport!"

Mal tried to put on a smile, but failed. He didn't need to meet Louis, nor did he need to see what he was buying. All he could think was that this jaunt across the channel was wasting time. He wanted to get back home, find Philippa and recover what she'd taken. Once that was taken care of, he

would be happy to go France. Maybe he could take Honey along, show her off, take her to Paris for a couple of days.

But he wasn't going to risk pissing off Lacey.

An hour later, they were sitting in the cabin of a twenty five-foot sports cruiser, sharing a bottle of wine. The water was quite choppy, and Mal wasn't a good sailor. His bad day was slowly getting worse.

* * * *

Jimmy thought he'd got a lead. A taxi company based in Chippenham said one of their cars had collected a fare from Bath an hour ago. The radio guy gave Jimmy the driver's mobile number, which he phoned immediately.

"So, it was a woman travelling on her own?"

"Yeah. I picked her up from a small B&B in Crescent Gardens."

"Was she a good-looking blonde, early twenties?"

"No, doesn't sound like her. This was a brunette. Good body, but her face was nothing special. All blotchy, like maybe she had a cold."

Jimmy's heart dropped. This didn't sound like Fizz. He was just about to hang up when the driver remembered something else.

"She had a funny shaped birthmark on her wrist—I noticed it when she paid me. I thought it was a tattoo at first."

That had to be her. Jimmy had noticed it many times. He checked his watch. "What time did you drop her off?"

"About twenty minutes ago."

"Do you know which train she caught?"

"No. How would I?"

"Cheers." Jimmy hung up, took out his car keys and called over to Jed, one of the Moondust bar-staff. "Come on. We're going to pick something up, and I may need your help getting it into the car."

As Jimmy made his way to the car he couldn't help wondering what Fizz had done to piss Mal off so badly. Jimmy had always fancied her, and there'd been two occasions when they'd been intimate. The first was during

a threesome. Philippa was laid out on a couch while someone, possibly Giff, straddled her chest so she could suck him off. Jimmy had spread her legs and fucked her, coming well before the man in her mouth was finished. The second occasion was shortly afterwards, in a limo during the journey back from Ascot races. She'd been out of her mind after drinking champagne and snorting coke, and Jimmy was just one of the three men she'd blown during the long drive home.

It had been during these first few months that Philippa's enthusiasm for all things sexual made her a popular addition to the crowd and earned her the nickname 'Fizz'. Although it was almost an abbreviated form of Philippa, it derived from a line that Giff used to say about her: *'Philippa Fizz, she likes your jiz'*.

Jimmy broke every speed limit as he drove from Bristol to Chippenham. They made remarkably good time and a lot of other drivers angry

When they arrived at Chippenham station, there was a train sitting at the platform. Jimmy had no way of knowing how many trains had stopped at the station since the taxi had left. He got out of the car and scanned the platform, but couldn't see Philippa.

He leaned back into the car. "Right, I'm going to have to get on that train. I want you to find out where it's going, then drive to the next station it's due to stop at. I'll be waiting for you there."

Jimmy ran onto the platform and boarded the train. Seconds later it pulled out of the station. Since he'd boarded through the door at the tail end of the platform, Jimmy reasoned she'd be sitting somewhere further forward—if she was onboard. He walked slowly through the carriages, checking the passengers on either side of the aisle. Philippa was sitting in the third carriage he tried, looking out of the window. She didn't seem to notice as he sat in the seat facing her.

"Hello, Fizz."

She jumped at his voice, and tears welled up in her eyes. He saw her dart a terrified look up the aisle to see if anyone else was lurking. He understood her being frightened.

"Mal would like to have a word with you, back in Bristol."

Philippa nodded, but didn't speak. The tears overflowed onto her cheeks.

He kept his voice low and calm. "When we get to the next station, we'll be getting off the train. Then we'll drive back to Bristol, and you and Mal can sort out whatever you need to. Okay?"

She just stared blankly at him, and nodded again. She went such a nasty colour he hoped she could manage to walk off the train without fainting. He didn't need a scene. As she went back to her mindless stare out of the window, he popped a quick text off to Mal. *We have her.*

* * * *

Lauren and Mark finished their pub lunch and went for a short walk around the country lanes. They chatted easily about their respective careers, their families, and even their love lives.

"You surprised me last night," Lauren said. "I thought that maybe Philippa was the one."

"The one?" Mark shook his head. "Nah. She's too young."

"I thought that was what you wanted—firm, pert, insatiable. Someone to look after, treasure, nurture into the perfect mate."

He knew Lauren was teasing him, but he also knew she cared about him and wanted him to be happy. He just laughed out loud, hoping she'd drop the subject. But she didn't seem to want to let it go.

"But she has a lot going for her."

Mark nodded his agreement, but offered no more.

"She's good looking."

"Definitely. Really nice smile, big blue eyes, long blonde hair, a great body." Mark looked around him. "God, I wish I was with her now."

Lauren punched his arm. Their walking pace seemed to have gotten slower and slower until they were finally standing on the quiet lane, facing each other.

"She seems really bubbly and good fun."

Mark nodded. He wasn't sure he liked where this was going. He was happy enjoying Lauren's company, but he didn't need the third degree over his part-time girlfriend.

"And she's exciting?"

Mark nodded enthusiastically. "God, yes. Oh, I could tell you some stories about that—"

"No, thank you." Lauren held his gaze, her face turning serious.

Mark looked down at his feet, then back into her eyes. He shrugged. "I just don't love her. Not the way I need to. And I'm pretty sure she doesn't love me, either."

Lauren looked briefly at the hills in the distance, and then back at him. "Do you really think she's seeing someone else?" Her voice was tender, caring.

Mark shrugged again. "I have no reason to really think she is. You know—I've not found scratches or love-bites on her body." He smiled, wickedly. "And believe me, I've looked."

Lauren was silent.

He shrugged for what seemed like the hundredth time. "I don't know what's drawing her back to Bath and Bristol every other weekend if it's not somebody else."

"Maybe it's just the social life, with no one in particular. You know—just all her mates and that?"

"Maybe," he conceded, and decided to try to steer the conversation into safer waters. "What about you, then?"

"Me? Oh I'm too busy trying to further my career to think about boyfriends."

Mark had to look away, not really wanting to be reminded of why they'd split in the first place. It wasn't just about his wanderlust—it was just as much about her focus on her job. He felt the light stroke on his arm and wasn't surprised to see the apologetic look on her face

"Sorry, I didn't mean it to sound that way."

"It's okay," he said, not very convincingly.

“What I meant to say was I’m happy with the way things are just now. I’m doing well at work. They may send me to Milan for a six-month secondment, which would be nice. And thanks to your help, I’m getting financially sorted so I no longer have to worry about selling the house.” She smirked. “And when I get lonely, I can go down to the local meat-market and pull some young stud to roger me senseless for hours on end.”

Mark nodded, showing this was a perfectly reasonable existence for the woman all his friends and family assumed he’d marry. “These studs you pull at the meat-market,” he said. “Do you have to pay them?”

“Fuck off.” She punched him on his arm, and it hurt.

“Come on, Jezebel,” he said, laughing. “Let’s head back.”

* * * *

Philippa sat in the back of the car as Jed drove, with Jimmy in the front passenger seat. There was no conversation. The silence was broken by Jimmy’s mobile making two short beeps. He read his text message, glanced back at her, and then told Jed to head for somewhere she hadn’t heard of. Her heart seemed to beat harder in her chest, and she could feel her legs shaking.

Jimmy turned around in his seat and looked at her. “I’ve just had a text from Giff. Apparently, him and Mal have to go to France and they won’t be back until tomorrow. So I’m going to take you home with me.”

Philippa was so relieved she wanted to laugh out loud. Instead, she just nodded and let out a long breath. The rest of the journey seemed to go a little quicker.

An hour later, Jed had driven off and Philippa and Jimmy were sitting in the lounge of his flat. Although they’d been part of the same crowd for over three years, the two of them had never really spent much time together. A thought suddenly struck her which made her feel ashamed. She couldn’t remember if she’d ever slept with Jimmy.

She thought long and hard, and couldn’t be certain one way or the other. She looked at him. He was in his late-thirties, with lifeless long

brown hair and a thin face. His small beady eyes made him look like a rodent. And here she was, trying to remember if she'd ever fucked him.

"Do you want a tea or coffee or anything?" Jimmy asked.

Philippa felt sick with fear, but her mouth was really dry. "A cup of tea would be nice, thanks."

Jimmy went off into the small area that was his kitchen, and a couple of minutes later came back with two mugs of tea, handing one to Philippa.

"Thanks." She attempted a smile, but couldn't quite manage to make it look convincing.

Jimmy sat down on the opposite chair, and the pair drank their tea in silence. Philippa caught him stealing glances at her legs and she wondered if she could maybe do a little deal to make Jimmy let her go. She was wearing a knee-length skirt with black leather boots and as she crossed her legs, she let her skirt ride up her thigh. It had the desired effect—Jimmy adjusted his position to get a better look. She took a couple more sips of her tea, and let the leg she had on the floor fall to one side, putting her almost sideways-on to him, giving him a full view of both her thighs, and probably a bit of her backside as well. She wished she'd worn stockings, but her bare legs seemed to be keeping him quite happy. She let him stare for a bit longer, and then she let her hand fall to her thigh as she pretended to scratch an itch.

As she watched his face, he looked up and seemed to realise what she was trying to do.

Philippa gave him a hopeful smile with no real conviction behind it. "So, I couldn't interest you in a bit of fun?"

Jimmy smiled, looking down at the expanse of flesh on view. "Fizz, you could interest me in a lot of fun."

"And would you be able to turn a blind eye while I sneaked out of the door afterwards?"

He was shaking his head before she'd finished her sentence. "That would be more than my life's worth. You may know some of the best ways to empty my sack, but believe me, if you're not here when Mal turns up tomorrow, he'll rip my sack off and make me eat my own balls."

She felt her tears threatening another appearance. Not because Jimmy had refused to help her, but because he'd simply reminded her of what she was to face tomorrow. It was going to be a long night.

* * * *

Mal, Louis and Ray Lacey sipped cognac in a small bistro in Dieppe while the waitress cleared their plates. Giff was in a nearby bar with Lacey's men, playing cards. Louis seemed happy with the meeting, and Mal was impressed that all the arrangements were in hand. The business relationship between Louis and Ray Lacey had apparently gone on for several years, and there'd never been any problems with customs at either end. This deal would make Mal a profit of almost half a million quid with the possibility to repeat the same arrangement in the spring, and maybe then go for something a little bigger later in the year.

They adjourned to some easy chairs by an open fire in a separate room, and Mal accepted a cigar from Louis. Now Fizz was safely tucked away with Jimmy, Mal could relax and look forward to expanding his horizons.



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Chapter Five

A second restless night left Philippa feeling terrible. When she looked at her reflection in the bathroom mirror on Monday morning, she was shocked. Her face was drawn, her eyes sunken and red-rimmed. Her skin seemed unusually pale, but she couldn't work out if she was really pale, or whether it was a contrast to the unfamiliar brown hair. While in the shower, Philippa heard Jimmy moving around the flat. He was obviously up and about. She brushed her teeth and went through to the lounge.

"Morning Fizz," Jimmy said. "Do you want anything, like a cup of tea or coffee?"

She'd spent the whole night worrying about today and here was Jimmy, playing the perfect host as if nothing were wrong. It was just surreal. She started to cry again and hated herself for it. "I just want to go home."

She knew Mal was going to hurt her. Last night she'd decided to come clean and tell him everything. She would get him his things back, explain why she'd taken them and beg forgiveness.

"Come on," Jimmy said, passing her a cup of tea. "Drink this and calm down."

She took the mug but her hands were shaking so much she spilled some and burnt her fingers. Tea dripped onto the carpet. "Sorry."

"It's okay—this carpet's had a lot worse on it." Jimmy tried for a reassuring smile, but he didn't quite manage to pull it off. They both knew things would be unpleasant later in the day.

Her heart started to beat faster in her chest when Jimmy's mobile phone rang. He answered it and listened for a few seconds, then ended the call without a single word.

"Mal's on his way across the channel now. He reckons he should get here sometime after lunch."

Philippa nodded, closed her eyes, and started sobbing again.

* * * *

Mark was still in the shower when he heard the front door bang as Lauren left for work. Fifteen minutes later he walked into the kitchen and reheated the kettle. Lauren had left his mail on the table. There were two letters. One was the expected car tax demand, made obvious by the DVLA logo on the envelope.. The other was hand-written and Mark instantly recognised Philippa's untidy scrawl. He opened her letter first, and a small silver key fell out. Mark unfolded the single sheet of paper and read the short note. He turned the paper over, saw nothing extra on the other side, and turned it back to re-read the few lines Philippa had written.

Then he dialled her mobile. It went straight to voicemail. There was no answer at her flat, either. Next he tried her extension at work. This also went to voicemail. Finally, Mark phoned his own colleague from the network-support team.

"Hi Steve, it's Mark. Can you do me a quick favour? Would you go and see if Philippa's arrived at work yet, please?"

A couple of minutes later, Steve informed him that Philippa wasn't in her office, and that none of the girls in there had seen her yet.

"Okay, cheers. Could you do me another favour? Can you let Barry know I won't be coming in to work today?" Mark quickly made up a lie. "I think Philippa may be having car trouble, so I'll probably have to help her get it sorted. Yeah, tell him I'll take a day's holiday. Cheers mate."

Mark poured himself a coffee, then went upstairs to turn on his laptop. A few clicks later, he'd printed out directions to The Stargazer in Bristol. He didn't bother with breakfast. Philippa's note had unnerved him. Why was she in trouble? Who was Mal Marsden? She'd mentioned Emily a few times, but Mark had never met her. He put her note back into the envelope and the silver key in his pocket then headed for the door. It took him less than fifteen minutes to make it to the motorway, where he headed south. He knew the traffic would be a nightmare around Birmingham, and expected his journey to take about two and a half hours.

* * * *

Mal saw Giff being sick over the side for the third time and watched in disgust as the seagulls swooped to pick through the mess floating next to the boat.

“It looks like your boy hasn’t found his sea legs yet.” Ray Lacey was smiling as the wind blew into his face. Although it was still before ten in the morning, he was sipping whiskey and smoking a cigar.

Mal had declined both when offered. He wasn’t feeling too good himself, and he made sure he stayed upwind of Giff. The slightest smell of vomit may well add the contents of his own stomach to the seagulls’ breakfast.

“So,” continued Ray. “We’ve a green light for the day after tomorrow. Louis is a good bloke and he doesn’t let anyone down. If he gives you a time and a place, he’ll deliver and expect the same from you. Piss him off once and he’ll make you regret it, then never trust you again”

Mal nodded. “That’s fair enough.”

* * * *

Mark reached Bristol at around eleven forty-five, but it took him another twenty minutes to find the pub. The street maps he’d printed off didn’t show which roads were one-way or pedestrian-only. In the end he parked a couple of streets away and walked the final few hundred yards.

The Stargazer was a small double-fronted unit within a red-brick terrace. Inside was open-plan, with a polished wooden bar along the wall opposite the front door, and a coal fire blazing away against the far left-hand wall. Several of the tables were occupied, as were a couple of the stools by the bar. There were two barmaids.

The blonde one moved towards him and smiled. “Yes, love. What can I get you?”

He ordered a pint of Guinness. The girl wrapped a red-nailed hand around the beer pump, poured the black liquid until the glass was about three-quarters full, then left it to settle.

“Is that everything?”

“Yes, thanks.”

“Three pounds eighty.”

Mark paid the barmaid, wondering if she were Emily. She looked a little like Philippa; they were both about five-six, blonde and slim. Philippa was probably a bit prettier, Mark thought with pride.

The barmaid returned with his change and then topped up his pint, expertly drawing a shamrock into the head of the beer.

As she placed the glass on the bar in front of Mark, he gave her a polite smile. “Excuse me, but are you Emily?”

The blonde smiled but shook her head. “No, sorry. I’m Lisa.”

She looked at the other barmaid for a second, as if waiting to see if she was going to say anything, and then back at Mark when the other girl stayed silent.

Mark looked from one to the other, and then tried another tack. “My name’s Mark. I’m going out with a girl called Philippa. She told me that her friend Emily works here, and asked me to come and see her.”

“Oh, hi,” said the other barmaid. “Sorry, yes. I’m Emily.”

Mark nodded, trying to look like he understood why she hadn’t said anything until he’d explained who he was. He looked around at the other customers at the bar. Nobody seemed to be waiting to be served. “Could you spare me a minute?”

Emily looked at Lisa, who nodded that she could manage the bar on her own for a while. “Grab a table, I’ll come around there,” she told him.

He found a table near a window. Emily joined him, carrying a glass of coke. She was tiny, probably not much over five feet, and very slim. She had dark-brown hair cut very short like a man’s. Her pale blue eyes seemed to twinkle behind her wire-framed glasses. Mark thought she looked like an elf, and wondered if she was of Irish descent. She wore a very short blue and black chequered dress and black leggings.

As Emily sat down opposite, Mark passed her the note he'd received from Philippa.

"This arrived at my house this morning." He gave her a moment to read it. "I tried calling her but got no reply from her mobile or flat. I also tried her at work, and nobody there's seen her today either."

Emily's eyes were scanning through the letter again. Then she looked up. "She left her mobile in my flat. I called her on Saturday evening and heard it ringing in the bedroom. She must have forgotten to take it with her."

"She left here on Saturday?" Mark blinked—Philippa had told him she'd be staying with Emily all weekend.

Emily nodded.

"And you haven't heard from her since?"

He began to feel really unsettled when Emily shook her head. He thought she was about to say something, but when she didn't, asked his next question. "Who's Mal Marsden, and why would he be after Philippa?"

"Mal is my boss. He owns this pub and a few other places in town."

"So why would he be after Philippa? And why would she say she was in trouble because a pub landlord was looking for her?"

"I don't know." Emily glanced back to check that Lisa was coping with the customers—she was.

Mark nodded towards the letter, still in Emily's hand. "She seemed to think that you'd be able to explain things."

Emily looked back at the letter, as if to check he was telling the truth. She looked up at him. "Do you want to try and phone her at work again, see if she's turned up yet?"

He nodded. It had been before nine when he'd called this morning, so maybe Philippa was now at work, wondering where he was. "Is there a public phone about?"

She seemed surprised at the question. "Er, I don't think so. Wait here, I'll go and get my mobile."

When she returned, Mark called her work number and it was answered on the third ring.

“Philippa Roberts’ phone, Dianna speaking.”

“Hiya Di, it’s Mark. Is Philippa around?”

He could feel Emily watching his face as Di told him she hadn’t shown up. He ended the call and handed the phone back to Emily.

Emily took a deep breath. “Okay. Well, first off, I have to say I have no idea where she is.”

He didn’t interrupt. He thought that Emily seemed reluctant to tell him anything, so decided to save any questions until he knew more about what was going on.

“Fizz came down on Friday and we went out to the usual places. We had a couple of drinks in town then went to get something to eat. We went back to Moondust for a night cap.”

Emily paused and Mark stayed quiet. She cleared her throat.

“Okay, so we got home sometime around half-two, and Fizz told me she had to go home the next day. I thought she was staying for the whole weekend, but she said she’d got a party on back home, and had only just remembered to tell me.”

Mark was puzzled, trying to remember if anyone at work had had a party on Saturday night. His mind raced with possibilities— maybe Philippa was actually seeing someone else back in Cheshire.

“I had to be here for nine on Saturday morning—we serve coffee and stuff—and that was it. I said I’d see her in a few weeks, and left. Then later on Giff came in here asking where she was.”

“Giff?”

“He works for Mal.”

“Giff? Is that his real name?”

“No. I think his first name’s Jeremy or something, but his last name’s Gifford. Everyone calls him Giff.”

Mark nodded. “Anything’s better than Jeremy, I suppose.”

She smiled, and Mark realised how pretty she was.

“Don’t let him hear you say that. He’s a prat—thinks he’s God’s gift. But he’s also a happy slapper.”

“Which means?”

“He likes to bully people. He’s had a charisma by-pass and doesn’t like people who answer him back. Or out-shine him in the personality stakes, which isn’t difficult. So I don’t think you should mention your thoughts on the choice between Giff and Jeremy to his face.”

“Oh.” He was beginning to feel uneasy. “Did he say why he wanted Philippa?”

Emily shook her head. “He said Mal wanted her. And that Fizz had taken something.”

“What—like drugs?”

“What?” She looked confused, but then seemed to understand what he’d meant. “No, not taken something as in ingested, but taken as in stolen.”

“Philippa? What would she want to steal?”

“I have no idea. And I don’t know if Giff was just winding me up. We don’t really get on. But when he mentioned her car, I started to get worried.”

“Her car? What about it?”

“He said it had been found wheel-clamped at the university.”

Mark was losing track. “Why would she go to the university?”

“I’ve no idea. I tried phoning her mobile, but got no answer. When I got home after my shift, I tried her again. That was when I found her mobile in the bedroom.”

“Do you know where her car is? Which university building?”

“No, why?”

He took out the silver key from his pocket, trying to think. “This is the key she mentioned in the letter. I was wondering what lock it was for. Maybe if I find her car, I’ll find out what the key fits.”

Emily glanced at her watch. “I’ve got to stay here until after the lunch hour rush, which usually tails off after half-one. If you wait, I can come with you.”

Mark thought a little local knowledge would help and appreciated the offer, but he was more worried about Philippa being hunted down by some guy than what had been hidden away somewhere and secured with a

lock. “How about this Mal, is he here now? Should I ask him if he knows where Philippa is?”

Emily shook her head quickly, looking worried. “If I were you I’d try to avoid meeting Mal altogether. If he’s mad at Philippa for some reason, then he won’t be nice to be around.”

Mark was getting a very bad feeling about the whole situation. He decided finding Philippa’s car may be the best way to proceed. The smell of the food reminded him he’d skipped breakfast, so he ordered himself a burger and chips. Because the pub was relatively quiet, he’d only just cleaned his plate when Emily was allowed to leave.

They walked in silence to where Mark had left his car. Emily directed him out of the centre and onto the A4 towards Bath.

“So,” Mark said, trying to make conversation. “Were you at university with Philippa?”

“No. I did my degree in Cardiff, but did a post-graduate course at Bath. Then I decided to take a year out, save some money and then go travelling.”

He nodded, smiling. “Excellent idea. You should definitely do it. I loved it and would recommend it to anyone.”

He could feel her looking at him, but could only make eye contact briefly because he was driving. Then she sighed and went on.

“Well, I said I’d save up for a year—and three years later I’m still here. I don’t know if I’m getting cold feet, or just more settled in my ways in my old age.”

Mark laughed out loud. “Yeah, you’re really getting on, aren’t you? You must be all of twenty-three.”

“Twenty-five, but you’re right. I’m just trying to justify why I’m still here, when the truth is it’s because I just haven’t got around to getting off my backside and sorting it out.”

“So, did you meet Philippa while you were working in the pub we just left?”

“No. It was in another club owned by Mal, called Venus.”

He had the feeling there was something she wasn't telling him but tried keeping the tone light in the hope that she'd unwind at some point and start trusting him.

"Venus? Sounds like Mal Marsden has an interest in astronomy."

Emily laughed. "I don't know if he really does—I can't imagine him sitting for hours with his eye to the telescope. But you're right about the bars he owns. His pub is called The Stargazer, and he has a wine bar called Moondust. He also owns two clubs, Galaxy and Venus."

"And I'm sure they're all out of this world."

Her groan told him exactly what she thought of the quality of his puns.

Mark was thinking of a way to get back to his questions about what brought Philippa back to Bath every other weekend, when Emily interrupted his thoughts.

"You're going to be turning right up here, where that blue car's pulling out."

Mark turned where she'd directed, and saw a sign for the university. They followed a narrow road for about two hundred yards and then several large brick buildings came into view. They were surrounded by wide areas of grass, with parking space for several cars outside each building. Mark assumed they were halls of residence. They drove slowly around but Philippa's car was nowhere to be seen.

"Okay, let's try another," said Emily.

He manoeuvred the car around the parking area and headed back towards the main road. A few minutes later they pulled into another site. This too was a residential area, and again there was no sign of Philippa's car.

"Do you think maybe we should go to the university itself?" Mark suggested.

"Sorry," Emily said. "I was just doing all the buildings in order as we passed them on our way into town. Do you want to go straight there now?"

Mark shook his head. "No, your plan's a good one. Let's keep going."

The next they tried was a much larger site. There was a big building that obviously held classrooms of some description, and there was also a sports complex. What looked like a sports hall was just to the left of the road, with tennis courts and a five-a-side pitch to one side, and several football fields behind. Parked close to the door of the sports hall was Philippa's silver Fiesta.

Mark had a sudden thought. "How much do you want to bet that the key fits a locker in the changing room?"

Emily looked at him and smacked her own forehead. "Of course—why didn't I think? Me and Philippa are both alumni members of the campus, so we can still use the sports facilities, library and such. We actually went to see a couple of bands in the student union bar a couple of months back. But we usually use the Sports Training Village at Claverton Down, as that's got the pool and best facilities. Do you think that whatever Philippa stole from Mal is hidden there?"

"Only one way to find out." Parking in the next space to Philippa's car, Mark noticed the clamp on her front wheel.

Just inside the doors they found the security gate. Emily dug into her purse and pulled out her security ID card. She held it out for Mark.

He shook his head and handed her the key. "I expect Philippa would have used the girls' room."

* * * *

Emily found the lockers at the far end of the changing room. The silver key in her hand had a number seven engraved on the head, but otherwise looked like all the other keys still in the locks of the vacant lockers. When she inserted her key into locker number seven, it opened. Inside was a plastic carrier bag with a *River Island* logo on the side. Emily took out the bag, and checked around the locker. There was nothing else in it. She pulled open the carrier bag and saw that whatever was inside was wrapped up in a black bin liner.

She didn't feel comfortable enough to see what the bag contained while she was by herself, so she took it back to where Mark was waiting.

He looked at the bag, and then at Emily.

“What is it?”

“I don’t know, but this is all that was in the locker.” She handed the bag to Mark, who looked around the empty entrance hall.

“Shall we take it to the car and look at it there?”

She nodded and led the way back outside into the dull afternoon. Once inside the car, Mark reached into the bag and pulled out the bin-lined package. Even before he unrolled the bin liner to look inside, Emily knew what they’d find. The familiar size of the contents, the low weight, and the sound they made as they banged together as he reached his hand in to get them. He pulled out four DVD cases.

“Any ideas what these could be?”

She swallowed, having a pretty good idea, but not wanting to go there. “Not really, no.”

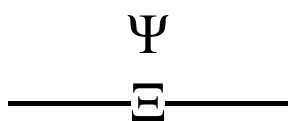
He raised a brow at her.

“Is that all there is?” she asked.

Mark pushed his hand inside the bin liner again and rummaged around, feeling into each corner. “Nothing else.” He folded the empty black liner flat and rolled it up to show her it was completely empty. Then he started the car and fastened his seat belt. “Well, I suppose there’s only one way to find out what’s on the discs.”

She nodded and fastened her own belt. Their journey back to Bristol was done in almost total silence.





Chapter Six

Honey was sitting at the bar in Moondust chatting to Denise, a recent addition to the bar staff, when Mal and Giff returned from their trip. She smiled at Mal as he approached. “Hey, babe. How was France?”

He pulled a face. “France was fine, but any future visits will be done using a fucking aeroplane.”

Honey laughed and got up from her stool, kissing him on the cheek. “D’you want a drink here, or would you rather have a coffee upstairs?”

“No thanks. I’m off to get this thing sorted with Fizz.”

Honey moved closer to him and placed a hand on his arm. “C’mon, let’s nip upstairs for a coffee first. It’ll do you good.”

As the pair of them moved towards the stairs, Honey saw Giff sit on the stool she’d been using, obviously eager to chat to Denise. She was probably one of the few barmaids he hadn’t taken to bed yet.

Once in the lounge, Honey put the kettle on, but she didn’t expect to need the boiling water—she had a better way of relaxing Mal. She moved close behind him and slid her arms around his waist. “How long d’you think you’ll be?”

Mal let out a breath and rested his head back against her. “As long as it takes for her to return what she took, and tell me what she’s up to. She’d better not try pissing me about, because I’m not in the fucking mood.”

Honey gently ran her hands over his stomach before moving them down to rest over his crotch. “Are you sure you’re not in the fucking mood?” As her fingers gently stroked him through the material of his trousers she felt his cock start to swell.

When Mal turned to face her she raised her eyebrows a little, pleased at the effect her fingers were having on him.

“What I was thinking,” she said in a sultry voice, “was that if you were to go and see Fizz with all that pent up energy...” She gripped his erection through the fabric of his pants. “Well, you might do something nasty to her, and then regret it later.” With expert fingers, she undid his zip and took out his cock. Holding it in one hand, she traced the nails of her other hand gently down the full length of the shaft.

“Whereas if you were to burn off all of that pent up energy doing something nasty to me...” Honey smiled. She knew she was going to get what she wanted.

With both hands still on his cock, Honey led him to the couch and sat down. She slowly raised her skirt up her thighs, revealing the thin white gusset of her g-string. She let her legs fall apart and used a finger to pull the white silk to one side, exposing the neatly-trimmed triangle of black hair. Her sex glistened with juices, the pinkness of her outer lips enhanced by the pale brown skin surrounding it. Mal bent over and gripped her legs behind each knee, then pulled her forwards until she was sitting right at the edge of the seat.

Dropping onto his knees, he guided himself inside her. She was already very wet, and he slid into her easily. Honey let out a low groan, and wrapped one of her legs around his waist.

He was watching her face as he fucked her, and she made sure he got the full show. She half-closed her beautiful dark brown eyes, made a perfect circle with the red-painted mouth, whispered ‘Ooh’ with each of his thrusts. She moved her hips up and down with his strokes, and took her bottom lip between her teeth. Honey started to come, and Mal maintained the same rhythm. But Honey used the leg around his waist to pull him into her at a quicker rate, until she was kicking him like a jockey spurring on a horse to the finishing line.

Honey cried out as her orgasm peaked, then pushed herself against him, grinding her clitoris against his pubic bone as she searched for a second high. The roughness of the trouser material gave her added pleasure. She achieved her second orgasm, but this one wasn’t as powerful as the first. She allowed herself to enjoy the ride on the last few waves, and then knew it was time to let Mal have his release.

She lifted her legs up, resting them on his shoulders, and looked straight into his eyes. “Okay, now I want you to fuck my brains out.”

Mal breathed hard through gritted teeth. Gripping her legs, he pulled her onto his thrusting cock, over and over until suddenly she knew he was shooting his load deep inside her. Mal bucked and grunted. When he was fully spent, he slowed his movements gradually until he stopped altogether. From the expression on his face, Honey surmised it had been an intense orgasm. She sensed him relax, all the tension dissipating. When he opened his eyes she smiled at him.

“Well, isn’t that better?” she asked.

Mal was breathing so heavily he couldn’t answer.

Honey laughed. “I’ll take that as a yes, then.”

* * * *

Mark took the DVDs from the bag. Each case had a hand-written label stuck to the front. The first he picked up was titled *Spider’s Return*. Mark passed it to Emily, who read the label before inserting disc into the DVD player beneath the television. She hesitated, and looked at Mark. He reached over and picked up the remote. He hit ‘play’. Emily sat on the floor by the television and Mark on the settee, leaning forwards. For a few seconds the screen showed blackness and silence, and then an unsteady view of the inside of a bar emerged. It was obviously a home-made recording. The camera was being carried shakily around a crowded room, capturing many smiling faces. Someone in the background said something that wasn’t clear, and the camera was pointed towards a closed door. The room became quieter as everyone stopped talking, the silence interrupted by the occasional snigger.

The door opened and a man entered the room. He stopped in his tracks as a loud cheer came up from the crowd. His expression made it obvious the reception was a complete shock. The picture shook erratically as the words ‘Hey, Spider Man’ boomed loud, the voice presumably belonging to the person pointing the camera. Then the guest of honour was surrounded by the crowd as everyone shook his hand and hugged him.

Emily leant over to tap 'pause' and looked at Mark. "Well, I know who that is, but I wouldn't say I really know him. It's not Mal, but someone who used to work for him. His name's Simon Webb, but everyone calls him Spider."

"Ah, as in Spider Web. Very funny—the long winter nights must just fly by down here." Mark looked back at the television, but Emily didn't restart the recording. He looked at her questioningly. "What?"

She looked down at the floor, then back into his eyes. "Maybe we shouldn't watch these but just keep them 'til we see Fizz."

Mark said nothing for a few seconds. "You know what's on them, don't you?"

"I have a good idea, yes."

"And you think I shouldn't see them?"

"I have no problem with you seeing them, but I'd rather Fizz showed them to you."

"But she's not here, and she asked me to look after them." Mark was beginning to get annoyed.

"She didn't ask you to look after the DVDs. She asked you to look after a key."

"Yes, but it was the key to the locker containing the discs." Mark looked back at the screen, making it obvious that the discussion was over.

Emily resumed the playback. There seemed to be about forty people or so in the room, the vast majority of whom were men. The lighting changed and somebody shouted something Mark couldn't make out, but everyone laughed and cheered. Then the camera was pointed towards a small stage fitted with a chrome pole in the centre and a wooden chair a few feet from the pole. Spider was helped onto the stage by a thin man with long straggly hair. Spider sat down in the chair.

Loud music started to play, a hip-hop song with a strong drum beat and rhythmic bass line Mark didn't recognise. A cheer came up from the audience as a girl walked into view on the stage. Mark could tell it was Philippa immediately. As the camera zoomed in on her, Mark saw she looked much younger, but that may have been down to her outfit. She was dressed as a schoolgirl, but her uniform noticeably raunchier than anything

seen in the playground. The top three buttons of her white blouse were undone, showing off her cleavage. A loosened blue and yellow-striped tie hung over the swell of her breasts, the knot slightly to one side. The skirt was black and very short, with a slit up each side. Long black socks reached up over her knees to mid-thigh, and the black shoes had four-inch spiked heels. Her blond hair was much longer than she wore it now, tied in pigtails over each ear. Her make-up was way over the top, with bright red lipstick and thick mascara.

Philippa started to gyrate to the beat, and the crowd clapped their hands in time with the music. Spider was also clapping his hands, his eyes fixed on Philippa. Mark studied him. Spider was in his mid-forties and had thick black hair, greased back in the fashion Elvis had made popular half a century earlier. He wore a white open-necked shirt and a grey suit. The backs of both hands were covered in blue tattooed spider's webs. He had a cigarette in his mouth and a confident grin.

Mark took an instant dislike to him, having a good idea where the film's title had come from. "He'd just been released from prison, hadn't he?"

Emily kept staring at the screen. She nodded once.

As the crowd cheered, Philippa undid the knot of her tie and passed it between her legs for a few seconds like a stripper with a feather boa. She walked forward and draped the tie around Spider's neck. He made a point of looking at the crowd and sniffing the tie, for which he got a few laughs. Philippa slowly undid the buttons of her blouse and danced directly in front of Spider, letting the blouse hang open as she moved. Mark could see Spider talking to her as she danced for him, but there was no way the microphone could pick up what he was saying. Philippa turned back towards the audience with a big smile. As she leaned back and straightened her arms, the blouse slid to the floor. This was greeted by another cheer from the crowd.

Philippa had once told Mark she'd been a dancer in a club and Mark had made lewd comments about it. She'd laughed and said it'd been in a reputable place and he had a dirty mind, which was why she liked him. As Mark watched the film, he wondered if maybe he'd been a little naïve for believing her. This place didn't seem particularly reputable and she'd given

the impression her role had been more of a ‘dancing girls behind the DJ’ type of thing.

Mark and Emily watched the younger Philippa perform her dance in the film. She was now dressed all in black: shoes, stockings, skirt and bra. The next item to be removed was her skirt, and several wolf whistles could be heard at the sight of her in the black g-string. She turned her back on Spider, bent over and wiggled her backside in his face. He leaned forwards and almost fell off his chair as he tried to bite her. Facing him again, Philippa reached behind her back and unclipped the bra. She held the cups in place over her boobs as she edged a little closer to him.

The camera moved to the right to get a better angle. The picture became unsteady, briefly showing just the floor and the man’s feet. When it settled on the performance again, the view was from much closer. It looked like the cameraman had positioned himself right at the edge of the stage.

Philippa was now topless, her nice firm breasts sticking out for everyone to see. She leaned forward and retrieved her tie from around Spider’s neck, wrapping it around her boobs as if lashing together two footballs. Then she pulled it tight, crushing her tits together. With them sticking out like that, she walked up to Spider and straddled his legs. He pushed his face greedily into her chest, taking each nipple in turn into his mouth. Philippa just looked at the crowd and smiled, her body still moving in time to the drums and bass. Her hand was stroking the back of his greasy head.

Mark felt sick. Lauren often teased him for being almost ten years older than Philippa, but Spider was old enough to be her father. Philippa was probably about eighteen in this film, and Spider well into his forties. Mark wondered if Philippa had met Spider before this film was taken, but realised it was unlikely. She couldn’t have been at university for long, and he’d been away in prison. Mark wondered why he was trying to justify what he was seeing. Was it hope that she was doing it as a treat for Spider because they were friends?

Philippa was dancing again. She made her way over to the side of the stage where someone passed her something. The camera focused on it, and Mark could see it was a flick-knife. She danced her way back to just in front of Spider’s chair and Mark saw her speaking as she passed him the

knife. Spider slid a finger inside the thin strap of her g-string and used the knife to cut through the cord. He repeated it on the other side and pulled the small piece of silk from between her legs. Philippa was now naked except for the shoes and stockings. The music came to an end, and the crowd cheered and clapped.

Mark breathed a sigh of relief when it was over, but he still felt sick. He was just about to say something to Emily when another song started to play, and he realised the show wasn't over after all. This record was a slow rock number with guitars; the bass was playing with the rhythm of a heart-beat. It was another song that Mark didn't recognise and the lyrics weren't in English. On the screen Philippa was pole-dancing, wrapping her legs around it, climbing up, hanging upside down, sliding down the pole and rubbing her crotch against it, letting her head fall back as if she was in ecstasy. All the usual tricks, Mark surmised. But then she left the pole and started to crawl across the stage towards Spider. Mark was cold in the pit of his stomach. When Philippa reached her target, she knelt up between his legs and started to undo his zip.

The cameraman evidently decided to move a little more to the right, giving himself a perfect view. Philippa had Spider's cock in her hands, slowly stroking it. She leaned over his cock and as the camera zoomed in for a close-up, Philippa let a blob of saliva drop from her mouth onto the purple head of Spider's dick. Mark remembered her doing that to him after one of their Christmas parties just after they'd started seeing each other.

Philippa was moving her hand up and down Spider's cock with a twisting motion and Mark could see the man now had a full erection. Mark also noticed Spider was very well-endowed.

Philippa held the dick in her hand while she looked at the crowd. Mark couldn't help but think he was watching someone who was used to this sort of performance—she was interacting with the crowd with a lot of confidence. The cameraman shouted something about Spider 'having a full sack' and 'chances of her drowning'. Philippa looked in the direction of the voice and for a few brief seconds her eyes looked straight into the camera.

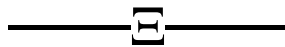
Mark held his breath. It seemed like Philippa could see him watching her, and he felt guilty for doing it. But the spell was broken when she looked back at Spider and licked her lips, and then lowered her head

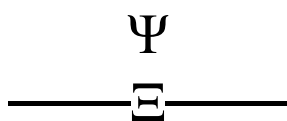
into his lap. She only managed to get just over half the length of his big cock into her mouth. She moved her head up and down his shaft several times. This time there was no cheer from the crowd, just a few murmurs. It was only then Mark realised the song had finished and no music was playing.

Philippa sucked Spider's cock for only a minute or so before she stood and turned her back on him. She bent her knees and lowered herself onto him, using her hand to guide his thick cock inside her. Mark watched in horror as Spider pulled Philippa downwards until his huge cock disappeared inside her. She winced for the briefest moment, but then her eyes closed and her lips pursed in the way Mark had seen many times. He knew Philippa was enjoying herself. Spider's hands were all over her body, the web-tattoos clearly visible as he roughly groped her breasts and legs.

After minutes of riding him like that, Philippa stood up and pulled Spider to his feet. Keeping her legs open and straight, she bent at the waist and rested her hands on the seat of the chair he'd been sitting on. Spider didn't hesitate to accept her invitation. He entered her from behind, taking her roughly with fast, hard thrusts. He was still fully dressed, so the only parts of his body to be seen were the blue-lined hands and the occasional glimpse of a thick, shiny length. Philippa's stockings had worked their way down to her knees, one slightly lower than the other. Her tits shook violently as Spider increased the intensity of his onslaught from behind.

Spider suddenly became very still for a few seconds, then he slammed into Philippa with force; one, two, three times. He paused again for a few more seconds and a few gulps of air, and then after two or three more hard thrusts from his hips he was evidently finished. He leaned forward and rested his hands on Philippa's back. The room was completely silent for a few seconds and then people were laughing, clapping and whistling. Just as the camera started to become unsteady again there was a glimpse of Philippa saying something to Spider, and then she stepped off the stage and out of picture. Spider walked towards the camera, smiling and zipping up his trousers. Then the screen went blue as the disc ended.





Chapter Seven

Philippa was standing by the window when Mal entered Jimmy's flat; she was so scared she couldn't speak. As it turned out, she didn't need to. As Mal approached he slapped her so hard he knocked her over. While she was still on the floor he kicked her in the stomach, winding her. He bent over and gripped her by the hair at the back of her head, pulling her face upwards until it was close to his own. She could taste blood in her mouth.

She tried to speak, but he shook her so violently by the hair she could only grimace in pain.

"You have something that belongs to me, and I want it back. Now!"

She tried to nod, but couldn't move her head. Mal was gripping her hair so tightly she thought he might actually pull it out. She tried to speak again, but once more he stopped her by shaking her head.

"I don't want to hear a fucking word from you. I don't want your reasons. I don't want your excuses. And I don't want your fucking apologies."

Spittle flew from his mouth into her face. Philippa stared into eyes which looked black and lifeless, like a shark's.

"I just want what you took. You're going to take me to wherever it is, and get it back. And if you don't do that right now, I'm going to cut your fucking tits off."

Mal let go of her hair and pushed her head back to the floor. Philippa was sobbing so hard she could hardly breathe. She didn't attempt to get up, terrified Mal would hit her again. She curled her legs up to her chest to protect her stomach.

She saw Jimmy backing away, shifting from foot to foot in the doorway of his kitchen like he was the one being threatened. Giff seemed quite happy where he was, standing over her. Her skirt had bunched up round her waist and he was copping a look at her thighs and arse.

Mal seemed to have calmed down a little and looked at Jimmy. "I'm assuming she had nothing on her when you picked her up."

Jimmy shook his head. "Nothing in her handbag."

Mal nodded in Philippa's direction. "Get her on her feet."

* * * *

The black Mercedes pulled into the parking space next to Philippa's car at the sports hall. Jimmy stayed in the car while Mal and Giff dragged Philippa from the back seat and pushed her in front of them.

"After you," Mal snarled.

Philippa used her ID card to get into the sports hall, and then had to hand it back to Mal and Giff for them to use. There were a few students standing by the drinks vending machine and they watched in silence as she walked across the reception hall and down the corridor towards the changing rooms, the men sticking close behind. Philippa pushed open the ladies' changing room door and looked back at Mal, waiting to see what he would do. He simply pushed her through the door and followed her in. Giff looked gutted that the changing room was empty.

As Philippa made her way across the room towards the lockers, her heart dropped. The key she'd posted to Mark was in the lock and the door was wide open. This meant Mark had probably seen the films, but right at this moment that was the least of her worries. She turned towards Mal, feeling panic rising.

"What is it?" Mal didn't sound as menacing as he had earlier, which helped Philippa get some words out.

"The locker's empty. They're gone."

Mal looked over her shoulder towards the wall of lockers. "How can it be empty?"

Philippa lowered her head, afraid to look into his eyes. "I, I sent the key to..."

Mal grabbed her by the throat and pushed her backwards, driving her all the way to the lockers as he walked with her, his hand squeezing her

throat tighter and tighter. Her back slammed against the closed doors. She started crying again.

“Who did you send the fucking key to?”

Philippa gasped for air, feeling light-headed. “I sent it to a friend,” she managed to whisper.

“And this friend is who, exactly?”

Without waiting for an answer, Mal slammed Philippa against the lockers again and again. When he finally let her go, she slumped to the floor, sobbing. Her back hurt, but her throat was killing. She could hardly draw breath, and was sure Mal had damaged her larynx.

“I fucking *knew* she’d been put up to this by somebody else.” Mal was now heading for the door. He looked at Giff and pointed at Philippa. “Bring her back to the car.”

* * * *

Mark sat in silence for a long time after the film had finished. Images of Philippa tumbled around his head: smiling at him the first thing in a morning with all her hair tousled; concentrating on some IT problem at work; closing her eyes and sucking Spider’s huge cock.

Emily interrupted his thoughts. “I told you we shouldn’t have watched it.”

“Have you seen it before?” He wasn’t sure why he wanted to know this, but for some reason it seemed important.

Emily shook her head.

“But you knew what it was. I saw the look on your face when you read the title.”

“I’d heard about the party, and what had gone on. I also knew it had been filmed.” Emily was looking back at the television screen, even though it was blank.

“And you knew what she’d done?”

Emily gave him a sarcastic smile. “What, did you think she was a virgin before she met you?”

Mark was surprised at her response. “No. But I didn’t think she’d fucked criminals in front of the general public, either.”

“Yes, well now you know.” Emily’s cheeks were red, and her blue eyes seemed to have sparks in them.

Mark couldn’t understand why Emily was mad at him. “What? Do you think this is something I should just take in my stride?”

“It was a long time ago. But I don’t think you should let it distract you from trying to save her.”

He stood up. “Save her? I think that’s a bit melodramatic. I came here to find her, that’s all.” He ran a hand through his hair. “You know what I thought driving down here today? I thought she’d tried to dump whoever she was sleeping with, and he’d done something like threatened to lock her up until she came to her senses and carried on seeing him.”

“You self-centred bastard.”

Mark was incredulous. “How do you work that out? I drove a hundred and fifty miles because I thought my girlfriend was in trouble with her other boyfriend. I don’t think that’s something everyone would do.”

“Why would you think that?”

“Because I’d never heard of Mal Marsden before I got the note, so I assumed he must have been the reason she came down here so often.”

“Maybe she came down here because she had more fun than when she was with you.”

Mark nodded towards the television. “She obviously did. If only she’d told me what turns her on, I could have borrowed a camera and hired Rent-a-Crowd.”

Emily stood up. “If you thought she was sleeping with somebody else, why are you making such a big deal about the film? That was taken years ago, anyway.”

“I think that’s a bit worse than having another boyfriend on the side, don’t you?”

Emily shook her head. “Why?”

“Why? She fucked somebody who she didn’t know on a stage in front of a room full of people. She fucked a man who had just got out of

prison and had unprotected sex. He could have been bumming the jail's resident rent-boy for all I know."

"Oh! Now I see. You're just worried that you may have caught something. Maybe you should have thought to wear a rubber when you fucked her?" Emily practically spat the words at him.

Mark took a deep breath, counted to ten and let the air out with a sigh. "What I'm saying is, up until fifteen minutes ago, I was under the impression that my girlfriend had a similar sexual history to the average girl. But now I know she doesn't. You saw the film, and you knew about what was in it." Mark had another thought. "And I assume she got some sort of financial reward for that performance, so we both know what that makes her."

"She didn't get paid for it, and she's not a whore," Emily said forcefully. "She likes a bit of fun, and yes she went too far sometimes. But she was young, and easily led."

Mark frowned and scratched his head. "Do you think Mal Marsden is the sort of person who would kidnap Philippa over a few dirty films?"

Emily was silent for a few seconds. "I've seen Mal cut somebody's finger off for trying to touch one of his dancers."

"Jesus." Mark felt sick again.

"Are you going to help her or not?"

Mark looked into her face, and nodded. "I'll phone the police, tell them Philippa is missing, and was hiding from Mal Marsden. They'll go and see him and make him let her go."

Emily looked horrified at the suggestion. "I don't think that's a good idea."

"Well, good idea or not, that's what I'm going to do."

Mark got the local station's direct enquiry number—he didn't think dialling 999 was the right way to go about things. A couple of minutes later, he was speaking to someone at Broadmead police station, explaining that a friend had been missing for a couple of days, and he'd received a letter from her which said someone called Mal Marsden was after her. He listened for a few seconds, and then looked up at Emily.

“What’s the address here?” He relayed it to the policeman and hung up. “They’re sending someone round to get the details.”

Emily was shaking her head again. “This is a big mistake. Mal won’t like the police being involved.”

“So he’ll be more likely to let Philippa go.”

“I don’t think so.” Emily gathered the DVDs. “And I noticed you told the police it was a missing ‘friend’. Why not ‘girlfriend’ or ‘lover’, as if I didn’t know?”

Mark sighed. He really couldn’t be bothered arguing with her over this—she’d never see his side of things. “Let’s just wait until the police get here, shall we?”

It took less than thirty minutes for them to arrive. Emily let the two men into the flat.

The one in plain clothes introduced himself, showing his ID. “Afternoon, sir. I’m Detective Sergeant Waltham, and this,” he nodded at the young officer in uniform, “is PC McKenna.”

“Mark Hicks, and this is Emily...” He realised he didn’t know Emily’s last name.

“Lawson,” she informed them. “Please, take a seat.”

The two policemen sat side by side on the settee. Mark sat in the only armchair, and Emily knelt on the floor by the fire. DS Waltham took a small notebook from the inside pocket of his jacket. “Can you start by telling me what you told the officer on the phone?”

Mark looked at Emily, and when he realised she was going to let him do all the talking, cleared his throat. “Yes. Well I live in Cheshire, as does my girlfriend. She came down to stay here with Emily,” he nodded in Emily’s direction. “For the weekend.”

Both policemen looked towards Emily and then back at Mark.

“And your girlfriend’s name?”

“Philippa. Philippa Roberts.”

The detective was writing this down. “And what makes you think she’s missing?”

Emily spoke. “She left here in a rush on Saturday morning. She hasn’t been seen since.”

“And this morning I received this letter.” Mark passed it over to the policeman.

The detective took the letter out of the envelope and read it. He turned the sheet over to check to see if there was anything on the back. There wasn’t. He read the note again, and looked inside the envelope.

“And the key that she mentioned?”

They exchanged a quick look, and then without thinking Mark said, “I have it. I don’t know what lock it opens, so I’ll just keep hold of it until I can give it to Philippa.”

The detective said nothing for a few moments. “Could I see it? I may be able to shed some light on what sort of key it is, what sort of lock it will fit, and so on.”

Mark nodded, and reached into his jeans pocket. He took out a bunch of keys and singled out the key to his filing cabinet at work. He held it up and passed the bunch to them.

The policemen looked at the key.

“I thought it looks like maybe a desk drawer, or a padlock,” Mark said.

The uniformed officer was nodding his agreement. DS Waltham said nothing, but passed the keys back. “What about her family? Where do they live, and have you contacted them?”

Mark suddenly felt foolish. He knew they lived in Lincoln but he’d never met them. Philippa rarely talked about them.

“Philippa doesn’t get on with her parents,” Emily said. “She hasn’t spoken to them in almost two years. She definitely wouldn’t have gone there.”

The detective seemed to consider this for a while. “How about brothers and sisters?”

Mark answered. “No. She had a brother, but he was killed in a car crash.”

The detective suddenly stood up, and the young constable followed his lead.

“Well,” DS Waltham said. “I’m afraid there’s not a lot I can do at the moment. Officially, it’s too soon for her to be classified as a ‘missing person’. And the fact that her immediate family haven’t been contacted to see if she’s there...” He was shaking his head, as if trying to find something helpful they wanted to hear.

“I’ll tell you what I’ll do,” he said. “I’ll get in touch with Mr. Marsden, and see if he’s heard from Miss Roberts. Is there a number where I can contact you?”

Mark looked at Emily.

“I’ll give you my mobile number.”

The detective passed her his notebook, and Emily wrote her name and number. Then she opened the door for them, and the policemen said their goodbyes.

Mark held the letter, and was still looking for the envelope it had arrived in when Emily interrupted him.

“Mark... The detective hardly made any notes. The only thing he’d actually written was Philippa’s name. Mal’s name wasn’t even there. Do you think that’s normal?”

Mark shrugged. “Maybe if he’s as infamous as you make out, the police already know where to find him.”



$$\Psi$$


Chapter Eight

Philippa knew her respite would only be brief. Sitting alone in the bedroom of Jimmy's flat, her mind raced as she tried to think of a way out of the mess. It felt like every decision she'd made so far had been wrong, the most obvious blunder being to think she could steal things from Mal and get away with it. She knew what he was like. She'd known him for over four years, and he'd always been the same. So *why* had she thought he'd let her just walk away?

Another mistake had been to involve Mark. Their relationship had never been serious enough to expect him to help her against people like Mal. All Mark ever wanted to do was to have fun and enjoy the moment. And that had been fine with her. They both seemed to treat every time they saw each other as if it was a one-night stand. They laughed a lot and they fucked a lot. They'd never talked about settling down together, and that had suited them both.

But Mark made Philippa feel like she was special, and not many men had been able to do that. She'd started to think that perhaps the two of them moving in together would have been the logical next step. Maybe that had been at the back of her mind when she decided to try and get the films back.

Philippa realised whatever she had wanted from a relationship with Mark was immaterial now. She felt sure he'd turn his back on her after seeing the films. Another thought struck her, and she went cold. What if Mark destroyed the discs and went back to Cheshire without bothering to try and find her? What would Mal do to her then?

* * * *

Emily paced by the window. "You can't just take them back. She went to a lot of trouble to get them. If you just lose your bottle now, then all

she's done is for nothing."

Mark stared across the room to where she was glaring at him and shrugged. "What else can I do?"

"Grow a pair of balls!"

"Look, I hate to disappoint you—"

Emily let out a laugh, but Mark persevered.

"I'm just an ordinary bloke! I work in IT. I solve network problems for people within the company—that's all I know. I'm not some Bruce Willis or Clint Eastwood character who can just ride into town and see off all the bad guys."

Emily didn't speak.

"I'm sorry I don't measure up to whatever you think a real man is, but I'm completely out of my depth here." Mark's voice was now calm, reasonable. He gave Emily the chance to respond, but she remained silent. "I thought if I took the DVDs back to Marsden, then if he *is* holding Philippa he'll let her go."

"But Philippa took a big risk getting them," Emily pointed out. Her voice sounded like she was almost pleading.

Mark nodded. "I appreciate that, but it looks like the risk didn't pay off." He thought of something else. "What if she sent the key to me because she knew that I'd use the DVDs in a trade to get her back?"

Emily said nothing and Mark saw this was something she hadn't considered.

"In fact," he went on, "she must have known she might have had to return them. Otherwise she wouldn't have bothered hiding them. She could have just destroyed them all when she first took them." He was nodding to himself now, convinced he was right. "Philippa knew she may get caught, and she needed the insurance. That's why she sent me the key."

Emily seemed to be still thinking about it, but Mark could tell from her resigned expression that she was beginning to see his point.

Finally they agreed he should go to see Mal Marsden and ask him to agree to release Philippa. In return, Mark would give him the DVDs back.

"I'll come with you," Emily said.

Mark frowned. "I don't think that'd be a good idea."

"Why not?"

"Well for a start you work for him, so I suppose he'd expect you to be on his side. If you turn up there with me, it'll make him think you were part of Philippa's plan. Maybe he'll think you helped her do it."

Emily's face blanched. "I never thought of that."

"Where would they have been kept?"

It took Emily a few moments to understand what he meant. "What, do you mean before? As in where did Fizz get them from?"

Mark nodded.

"I don't know. Somewhere in Mal's office, I expect."

"So how did she get in there?"

"It's just a room upstairs at Moondust. I don't think it's kept locked. She could have just walked up the stairs and into the office."

"Is it normal for people to go upstairs? Isn't that part private, separate from the public bar?"

Emily shook her head. "When the doors close and all the customers are gone, it's more like a house than a bar. People go upstairs to chill out, others play snooker in the back room, some sit at the bar and chat. It's like a laid-back party with no rules."

"Oh, right." Mark's inquisitive mind turned up another question—was there also a room where Philippa stripped and had sex during these laid-back parties?

* * * *

Mark got his first glimpse of Moondust as he drove past. He was surprised and impressed. It was a large Victorian detached building, set back from the main road with a cobbled area and old-fashioned streetlamps surrounding it. Four large windows faced the front. The inside looked warm and inviting.

He parked his car down a quiet street just off the main road. Emily had accompanied him this far because he didn't know the area but had

agreed to stay in the car while he went to see Mal. Mark left her his car keys, telling her to start the engine and turn the heater on if she got too cold. And they both felt better knowing Emily could drive to the police station if things went wrong.

Mark climbed out of the car and put the bag containing the DVDs in the large inside pocket of his coat. He tried to give Emily a reassuring smile.

“Good luck,” she said.

Once through the door, Mark found himself in a very large, busy room with a dark mahogany bar running along almost the full length of the rear wall. There must have been about fifty people around—the vast majority in their twenties and early thirties—creating a lot of chatter, but the place was well insulated. Hardly any echo. To the far right, an archway led into a side room. A series of chest-high tables with tall stools stood close to the bar. In the area nearer the windows there were low tables surrounded by comfortable leather armchairs and settees. It looked like a nice place to relax and have a drink. The lighting was subdued, and a good quality sound system played music by The Chemical Brothers.

Mark walked to the bar and ordered a bottle of Beck’s from a young man wearing a black shirt and wide selection of facial jewellery. There was nobody waiting to be served, so Mark decided now was as good a time as any. He tried to sound casual.

“Is Mal Marsden around?”

The barman glanced briefly at the group of four men sitting on stools at a nearby table, then at Mark. “He’s not about at the moment but he should be back in an hour or so.”

Mark nodded. “Okay, thanks.”

“Anything I can help you with?” When the barman raised his eyebrows, the metal bar inserted above his right eye made the skin pucker in a very unattractive way.

Mark watched it in horror and shook his head. “No, I’ll wait. Thanks anyway.”

* * * *

“Maybe take that consignment up with Jimmy in the van, then Jed can—” Mal cut off at the sound of his name being mentioned and glanced over at the bar. Then at Giff, who shook his head to confirm he didn’t recognise the newcomer, either.

Mal felt certain this was the person who’d put Philippa up to breaking into his safe.

Mal stood up and leant to whisper in Giff’s ear. “Stay here, and keep an eye on him.” Then he walked past Mark and around the corner. He took the stairs two at a time and found Honey sitting at her dressing table, applying her make-up.

“Hey babe, what’s up?” She didn’t turn round, but spoke to his reflection in the mirror.

“It would appear Fizz’s partner-in-crime has come to make his demands.”

This made Honey turn around to face him. “Really?”

“Well, somebody I don’t know’s just walked in and asked for me by name.”

She seemed to give this a little thought. “So, what do you think he’s going to say?”

“I won’t know ’til I go talk to him. But he fits the description of the man Waltham went to see earlier.”

“Who do you think he is?”

“I don’t know. He doesn’t look like much—just a regular guy. But I’m thinking he must want in on some action in the area. Maybe he sees this as a way of getting his foot in the door.”

Honey was nodding slowly. They both knew that was a possibility. “Have you any idea where he’s from?”

“I know where he lives. Crewe.”

“What’s there?”

“I don’t know yet, but I’ll be finding out.”

“D’you think he’s the real deal, or could he be just fronting for someone else?”

“Maybe,” Mal agreed. “It might be that someone wants to branch out a little.”

“Do you think so? Any ideas where from?”

Mal shrugged. “Manchester, Birmingham, Cardiff—could be anywhere.”

“Do you think Ray Lacey is behind it?”

Mal shook his head. “No. But the whole timing of it makes me wonder if someone’s heard a whisper about our arrangement with Louis, and wants to disrupt it.”

“So what are you going to do?”

“I’m going to talk to him. See what he has to say.” Mal headed for the door. “You should join us when you’re ready.” When he got back downstairs Mal called at the bar and poured himself a large whisky. Then he approached Mark. “I believe you’re looking for me.”

* * * *

“Are you Mr. Marsden?” Mark’s throat was a little dry, but he was relieved to hear his voice sounded normal. He was also pleased to see Mal wasn’t as physically intimidating as he’d expected, even if he made a point of not offering his hand.

“I am. And you are...?”

“I’m a friend of Philippa Roberts’, and I’m here to ask you about her whereabouts.”

“And what makes you think I know where she is?” Mal took a sip of his drink, his face giving away nothing.

Mark tried to keep his voice even. “I was led to believe you knew most things that went on around here.”

“Well there *is* something I seem to have lost sight of, as I’m sure you know.”

Mark was just about to answer when he caught sight of a beautiful black woman walking by the bar. She was wearing an electric-blue silk dress which clung to her body and emphasised her perfect hour-glass figure.

He couldn't take his eyes off her for a few seconds, but then he looked back at Mal. "I... Sorry. What?"

Mal smiled, and motioned the woman over, apparently proud of the effect she had on men. "Honey, let me introduce you to Mr. Hicks."

She smiled and held out her hand. Honey had a beautiful face, with sparkling dark eyes and perfect white teeth but Mark barely noticed these things as he shook her hand—his stomach went cold. Mal had introduced him by name, but Mark hadn't told him anything other than he was a friend of Philippa's. Evidently this visit was not a surprise.

When Mal spoke to Honey there was no hint of friendliness in his voice. "I believe he was just about to tell me he has something of mine."

Mark looked into Mal's dark eyes and suddenly understood why Emily was so scared of him. Mal Marsden had the look of a man who existed right on the edge of self-control—just one small step away from being a psychopath. Mark was reminded of Robert Carlyle's Begbie in *Trainspotting*.

Suddenly Mark realised they were waiting for him to reply. "I have something," he said, nodding. Mark looked from Mal to Honey, not quite sure how to continue. "Philippa sent me a key, and I have something I believe to be yours."

Mal was nodding. "Good. Wait here."

Mark shuffled from foot to foot as Mal had a short, pointed conversation with a guy at the bar, feeling too on edge to speak to the woman he'd been left with. Then Mal was back, nodding towards an unoccupied table near a window.

"So," Mal said, sitting down opposite Mark. "Where's my property?"

"Where's Philippa?" Mark noticed the guy at the bar was gone. He hoped Mal had just told the man to go and fetch her.

"She's somewhere she wishes she wasn't. Now stop fucking me about."

Mark was shocked by the ferocity in Mal's response. He reached inside his jacket and took out the carrier bag, placing it on the table between them.

Nobody moved. Mark looked across the table; Honey was looking straight back at him and Mal was looking at the carrier bag, confused. He reached out his hand and rotated the bag so that the opening faced him. Using just his finger and thumb he opened the bag and peered inside.

“What the fuck is this?”

Mark was stunned.

Mal leaned across the table. “I said what the fuck is *this*?” He knocked the carrier bag across the table towards Mark.

“I don’t understand. I thought these were yours.”

Mal opened the bag and flipped through the DVDs as he read the labels, then looked up at Mark. “Are you trying to be a fucking smart-arse? I want the fucking watch.”

Mark was struggling to make sense of what was happening. It was like his head was fogging with panic. “Well, now you’ve got them back you can watch them.”

Mal picked up the carrier bag and threw it across the room, then grabbed hold of Mark by the lapels, pulling him forwards until he was leaning uncomfortably across the table. Mal didn’t seem to care that everyone else in the bar was watching them.

“If I want to watch bimbos getting fucked, I go down to my own club and watch it in the flesh. So stop pissing me about.”

Mark steadied himself as he was pretty much thrown back into his chair, desperately trying to think what to do next. The possibility the tapes wouldn’t be enough to satisfy Mal’s demands had never occurred to him.

“I think you’re wasting my time.”

Before Mark could answer, Mal stood up.

“I suggest you go back and talk to your boss. I refuse to talk about any deals until I get the watch back.”

Mal beckoned Honey with a slight move of his head, and she stood and followed him. They disappeared through the archway and out of sight.

Mark looked around the bar and saw most people were still watching him. He stood up and saw the carrier bag on the floor by a chair—

one of the DVDs had fallen out. He picked up the bag and loose DVD, then walked out of the bar.

* * * *

Sitting inside Mark's car, Emily wondered what the outcome of the meeting would be. The possibilities ranged from Mark and Philippa walking out together—which Emily thought very unlikely—to Mark not coming out at all. This would then leave Emily with the task of going to the police and trying to convince them of some wrongdoing.

Looking around the street, Emily noticed it wasn't a residential area. All of the buildings were small industrial units, several of them looking deserted. She took off her glasses and placed them on the dashboard in front of her. Her stomach was in a tight knot and she bit her nails.

Suddenly her car door was pulled open and a hand reached in and grabbed her coat. Emily screamed. She saw it was Giff, and experienced a cold fear in the pit of her stomach. When Giff recognised Emily, his face broke into a humourless smile. He dragged her out of the car, tumbling her onto the pavement.

"Get your hands off me, you fucking ape!" Emily climbed to her feet and glared at him.

"I might have known you two dykes were in this thing together." Giff nodded to himself. "I think you'd better come and have a word with Mal."

"I don't know what you're talking about."

"Bollocks you don't. Get your fucking arse over here." Giff grabbed Emily and started to drag her up the road towards Moondust.

Emily tried to kick him but missed. Then she swung her arm and caught him on the side of his head with her fist. He turned and pushed her hard. Her back slammed against the side of the car and she cried out in pain. Lurching forwards again, she managed to kick him on the shin. As Giff leaned in to retaliate, Emily swung her right hand, scratching him on his cheek with her nails.

Giff lunged forwards and punched her hard in the stomach. Emily was winded, and Giff pushed her backwards over the car wheel arch and onto the bonnet.

“I’ll fucking show you,” he snarled. His hand reached for her coat and ripped it open. Buttons flew into the air, and then his hand was pulling up her dress.

“F-fuck off you... moron,” she gasped. When she tried to scream Giff held his hand over her mouth and banged her head down against the metal of the car bonnet before putting his face close to her ear.

“Looks like a bit of finger and fanny isn’t really doing it for you. Maybe that’s why you’re such a fucking miserable bitch. I think what you need is a good length of cock inside you.”

Giff gave a hard pull on the leggings Emily was wearing under her dress, and the elastic waistband snapped. He yanked them down and she felt the coldness of the car against her legs.

When Emily attempted to scream for a second time, Giff slapped her hard across the face. Momentarily dazed, she looked around, praying that a car would turn down the road and save her from this ordeal. But no car came. It was a dark, cold night in a quiet side street. There was nobody around to hear her.

She was pushed a little further up onto the bonnet and could no longer reach the ground. She tried to kick him, but he was much too strong for her. Giff held her body flat against the bonnet easily with one hand and pinned her legs against the car wing with his knees. He unzipped his trousers using his free hand, his dick already hard. As he pulled her legs apart and tried to move closer, she kicked her legs wildly. He punched her hard in the stomach again, and all the fight seemed to leave her.

Giff pushed his trousers down a little more, yanked the gusset of her knickers to one side and tried to get himself into the right position to enter her.

The warmth of his dick on her thighs made Emily start to fight again. She wriggled and kicked and swung punches. Giff pulled away and she saw him pull back his hand ready to punch her again. Suddenly somebody else was there, helping her. The other person pushed Giff away

from her with force, and because his trousers were halfway down he lost his balance, falling over.

Emily was pulled up off the car bonnet, and she was looking into Mark's face.

"Are you okay?"

She nodded.

"Get in the car. Quickly."

Giff was trying to get to his feet and pull up his trousers at the same time. Mark swung a foot and kicked him hard in the ribs, knocking him over again. Then he helped Emily into the car and slammed the door behind her. He ran around to the driver's side, jumped in and started the engine. Emily locked her door.

There was a loud bang on the car roof and Giff's face pressed up against Emily's window. He had three red lines on his left cheek where her fingers had scratched him. When he couldn't open the door, he banged hard on the glass with his fist.

Mark put the car in gear and it lurched forwards. Giff gave chase for a few yards but was soon left behind.

"That was Giff," she explained.

"I thought it might be."

There was no traffic approaching when they reached the T-junction at the main road, so Mark didn't have to stop. He swung out onto the main road and a few seconds later they were driving past Moondust, which looked deceptively welcoming.

* * * *

Mal sat at the kitchen table upstairs, a large glass of whiskey in his hand. Honey stood behind, massaging his shoulders. Mal gave a snort. "Did you see his face? Either he's a fucking good actor, or he thought all I wanted was the DVDs. I didn't even know those things were missing. Haven't they all been uploaded onto the hard drive now, anyway?"

“I think so.” Honey was still massaging him. “So, what’s your next move?”

“I don’t know.” Mal looked at his watch. “I need to call Louis in an hour. I’ll go and see Fizz after that, and find out who this guy really is.”

Then Mal had another thought and took out his phone. “I think maybe a favour from DS Waltham is in order.”

* * * *

Mark helped Emily up the stairs to her flat. She was still shaking, one hand holding up her ruined leggings, the other holding on to his arm. Once inside, she went straight to her bedroom. Mark went into the kitchen and put the kettle on, thinking a cup of tea or coffee might settle her nerves.

Emily came out of her bedroom wearing a white robe. “I think I’ll have a bath,” she said quietly.

“OK,” Mark said, moving a little towards her. “Emily,” he started, as gently as he could. “He didn’t manage to, you know, actually...”

She shook her head. “No. But if you hadn’t arrived when you did, I’m sure he would have done.”

Mark breathed a sigh of relief.

“I just find baths a good way to unwind,” she explained.

Mark nodded. He knew that Lauren felt the same way about baths—it was evidently a woman-thing. He smiled at her. “I’ve put the kettle on. Can I make you a drink or something?”

“Good idea.” Emily walked past him into the kitchen and selected a bottle of red wine from a rack built into the kitchen units then filled two glasses to the brim and passed one to Mark. She headed for the bathroom with her glass and the bottle, stopping at the doorway.

“Thank you.”

Mark sensed she was close to crying as she looked down at the floor. When she looked up again, her blue eyes were filled with tears.

“If you hadn’t come back when you did, I...”

Mark moved towards her, she recoiled. He stopped immediately. “When you’ve finished your bath, we need to talk.”

Emily looked startled, and then sighed as she remembered why they’d gone to Moondust in the first place. “God, I forgot to ask. What happened with Mal?”

Mark withdrew the bag of DVDs from his coat pocket. “I don’t think these were the only thing Philippa stole.”

Emily looked puzzled. “What do you mean?”

Mark described Mal’s reaction to the discs.

“Well, what else is missing?”

“I’m not sure. He said something about a watch, so I assume Philippa’s helped herself to some jewellery as well.”

“Could that have been in the locker and we didn’t see it?”

Mark shrugged. “You tell me. I didn’t go into the locker room—you did.”

“There was nothing else in the locker. I definitely checked.”

“So maybe Philippa kept the watch with her.” Mark had a thought. “Do you think she may have sold it already?”

Emily shook her head firmly. “Taking those films is one thing, and I can understand why she’d want to take them. But taking jewellery is thieving, and I don’t think Fizz would do that. Do you?”

He attempted a smile. “I’m probably the last person to ask what she would or wouldn’t do. I don’t think I really know her.”

Emily looked at him for a few seconds, then turned and went into the bathroom.

Mark heard the click of the lock followed by the gush of the taps. He took off his coat and sat down to drink the wine. He felt exhausted, physically and mentally. He suspected this was nothing compared to what Philippa was feeling right now.

* * * *

“Keep her there until tomorrow.” Mal’s voice came loud and clear through Jimmy’s phone. “And tell her that she’s in much deeper shit than she thought she was.”

Philippa watched Jimmy’s face as Mal cut the call at the other end, and he put down his phone. She bit her bottom lip, still expecting there to be a knock on the door at any minute. She wouldn’t put it past Mal to fuck with her head.

Jimmy seemed to pick up on the fear in her eyes. “Mal’s been busy dealing with some French bloke. He’s not coming round until tomorrow.”

Philippa let out a sigh of relief, and for a reason she didn’t understand she started to cry again. She’d built herself into such a state that the sudden release of the tension seemed too much for her.

Jimmy waited until her sobbing subsided. “Fizz, Mal said whoever you’re working with didn’t return what you took.”

Philippa froze. Did this mean that Mark had gone to see Mal and refused to give him the DVDs, or did it mean he’d watched them and driven back home?

“What did he say?”

“He said to tell you that your partner-in-crime didn’t come up with the goods.”

“So, did Mark go to see him?”

Jimmy shrugged. “Mal just said he didn’t come up with the goods. And from where you’re looking at it, that’s all that matters.”

Philippa sat in silence.

“Fizz, what exactly did you take?”

She looked at Jimmy, surprised. Surely Mal had told him? He’d even searched her bag. “I took some DVDs. You know—the ones of the parties.”

Jimmy looked confused. “Why?”

Philippa couldn’t answer. Jimmy persisted.

“How many did you take? There must be about fifty-odd.”

She realised he didn’t see the point. “I only took the ones with me in them.”

“Oh.” Jimmy thought for a moment. “So what’s up with Mal? Why’s he so riled about the DVDs?”

Philippa was now the confused one. “Because I stole them from his office, I suppose.”

Jimmy didn’t look convinced, which made her more nervous than ever.

* * * *

It was after midnight when Emily emerged from the bathroom. Mark was sitting in silence on the chair.

Emily noticed his glass was empty. “Do you want another drink? I’ve got a few more bottles.”

He smiled, but shook his head. “No thanks. Is it okay with you if I crash here for the night?”

“Yes, of course. Will you be okay on the sofa?”

“Yes, fine. Thanks.”

Emily got him a pillow and quilt from her room. “I’m sorry, but this flat doesn’t have another bedroom.”

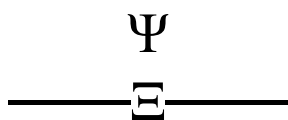
Mark took the bedding from her. “This will be fine. Thanks.”

They stood in silence for a few seconds, and then Emily cleared her throat. “I really appreciate what you did for me tonight.”

“I feel guilty for allowing you to go with me. But I’m glad I got there before he managed to get any further.”

Emily nodded again, and closed her eyes. “Me too.”





Chapter Nine

Mark awoke a little after six in the morning. He went into the bathroom and washed his face, then spread some toothpaste onto his finger, trying his best to clean his teeth. Back in the lounge, he dressed and folded up his quilt, placing his pillow on top of it. He boiled the kettle and made himself a cup of coffee.

It was almost an hour later when Emily joined him. She was still wearing the dressing gown, and her short hair was sticking up at strange angles after she'd gone to bed with it wet the previous night.

"Did you sleep all right on that thing?" Emily asked, nodding in the direction of the settee.

"Yes, fine thanks. How about you?"

She attempted a smile. "I was fine."

The truth was, he'd barely slept all night and he suspected she hadn't either.

"So," Emily continued. "Any ideas as to what we should try next?"

Mark shook his head. "Not really. But Marsden knew my name last night, and he could have only learned that from Philippa."

"Or the police," Emily said.

Mark looked at her, and remembered what she'd told him yesterday. He nodded reluctantly. "But he as good as told me last night he knew where Philippa was. Maybe I should drive back to Cheshire and tell the police there."

She frowned. "Wouldn't they just contact the police down here and ask them to look into it?"

Mark sighed. "Yes, probably. And I doubt they'd be very happy if I told them the Bristol police were corrupt."

Emily walked to the fridge. "I'm afraid I haven't got any cereal." She opened the fridge door. "Or milk." Then she checked a cupboard. "Or

bread.”

Mark laughed. “How about I go and get some provisions? Is there a shop nearby?”

Emily smiled her appreciation. “Thanks. There’s a Spar just down the next road—turn left at the end of this street, and it’s about twenty yards down there on your left. Let me give you some money.”

“No, it’s okay. But do you mind if I borrow your phone again? I’ll just let my boss know I’m taking another day’s holiday.” When he’d finished the phone call he handed Emily her mobile and pulled on his coat and headed for the door. “I won’t be long.”

“Right, I’ll boil the kettle and put some clothes on.”

Mark figured scrambled egg on toast for breakfast would be good. He bought the necessary ingredients, plus a toothbrush and some deodorant. He’d just walked out of the shop and turned the corner when someone punched him full in the face.

Mark was knocked backwards, but hands caught him before he could fall. He opened his eyes in time to see Giff throw a punch into his stomach. The wind flew from Mark’s lungs and he collapsed to his knees. The hands behind him pulled him back up to his feet. Another punch to the face made a blue-white flash appear somewhere behind his eyes, and then he seemed to drift away. The sounds of the street were no longer clear and his legs gave way. The hands holding him loosened their grip and allowed him to slide down to the pavement. As Mark lay half-conscious on the ground, he was kicked several times by all three men. He was only vaguely aware of the sound of their feet on the pavement as they ran away.

He heard a woman’s voice talking to him, but he couldn’t make out the words. The voice sounded muffled. Then a man was also talking, and Mark felt his head being lifted up. He opened his eyes. There were two people looking down at him, a middle-aged woman, and a young Asian man. The man helped him to sit up, and the lady passed him a wad of tissues. Mark tasted blood in his mouth, and felt his face swelling around his left eye. His vision was blurred and his whole body ached.

The lady was talking to him. “...saw them running off. They got into a black car, but I’m afraid I couldn’t see...”

Mark thought he was going to be sick. He leaned forwards and retched, but all that came out of his mouth was blood and spit. He wiped his mouth with the tissues and tried to stand up. The young man helped him to his feet as the lady picked up the carrier bag of groceries he'd bought.

"You should come and sit down while we call the police and an ambulance," the lady was saying.

Mark tried to shake his head, but it hurt too much. "I'll be okay, thanks." He pointed in the direction of Emily's flat. "I'm staying just down the road. I'll phone the police from there."

The lady seemed reluctant to let go of his hand. "Are you sure, dear?"

"Yes." He attempted to smile, but his lips were already too swollen. "Thank you for your help."

As he staggered away he heard the lady telling the man how this area had gotten worse over the last few years.

Emily's jaw dropped the moment she opened the door. "Oh my God!"

Mark's face felt weird, his left eye so swollen it was almost completely closed, the skin around it already tender. His nose and mouth were bleeding and his lower lip split open. The front of his coat was covered in blood and his jeans were ripped on one knee.

He held out the carrier bag of shopping. "I think the eggs may have been broken."

Emily grabbed him and helped him inside. "Shit. What have we got you into?"

"I'm okay," he said, although this was obviously not true.

"Come and sit down here." Emily led him towards the settee where he'd spent the night.

"I don't want to get blood all over your furniture."

"Don't worry about that." She ran into the bathroom and came back with a box of tissues.

Mark noticed Emily was wearing another very short dress, but hadn't yet put on any leggings or tights. Her legs were slim and pale. She

had nothing on her feet. She helped him out of his coat.

“I assume it was Giff.”

Mark nodded. “And a couple of his friends.”

“He’s such a twat.” Emily held a tissue against his lip, which was still bleeding. “I’ll go and run you a bath.”

A few minutes later Emily came and helped Mark to his feet. She walked him into the bathroom.

“OK, leave your clothes there on the floor, and I’ll put them in the washer.” Then she left, closing the door behind her.

His ribs were sore and his stomach ached. Mark wiped steam from the bathroom mirror and regarded his reflection. He raised a hand to his mouth and felt his teeth. None were missing, but one of them felt a bit loose in his gum. He removed all his clothes and left them in a pile by the door. He lowered himself into the bath which was full of water that felt much too hot. Emily had also added a lot of bubble-bath—the suds completely covered his body.

Emily came in and picked up his clothes. “I don’t think I can do anything about your coat.”

“Don’t worry about it. It’s quite old, anyway.”

A few minutes later Emily walked back into the bathroom. The steam condensed on her glasses, and she took them off and put them on the shelf over the sink. Kneeling down next to the bath, she picked up a sponge and dipped it into the water. Then she started to clean the blood away from his chin.

“I’m so sorry,” she said. There were tears in her eyes.

“It’s not your fault. You did warn me about calling him Jeremy.”

Emily laughed, but then her face turned serious again. “Does it hurt?”

“I suppose I should pretend that it doesn’t, so you think I’m hard.”

Emily laughed again. She kept wiping his face with the sponge, and then she washed his neck and chest.

She dipped the sponge into the water again, and he saw her look at his knees which were showing through the bubbles. The skin on one was

broken, and he remembered the rip in his jeans. She gently placed the sponge on the graze and held it there for a few seconds. Then she slowly started to slide the sponge down his thigh into the water.

The room seemed suddenly quiet. Mark looked at Emily, but she was looking at his knees. Her hand slid further down his leg until he felt the softness of the sponge against his groin. Then Emily let go of the sponge and wrapped her small hand around his dick. He became hard surprisingly quickly. She stroked him there for a few seconds, and only then did she look up and into his eyes. Neither of them spoke.

Emily stood up and slipped off her knickers. Still wearing her dress, she stepped into the bath. She stood with a leg either side of Mark's waist, and then lowered herself down. Mark held his erection upright with his hand and guided it inside her. She closed her eyes and parted her lips as he slid into her. Mark placed his hands around her tiny waist and held her still for a few seconds as he felt her inner muscles clench and release him several times.

When Emily rotated her hips Mark let out a quiet sigh. She opened her eyes and looked at him. A thin line of watery blood seeped from the gash in his lip, and his bruised eye was now completely closed. But none of this mattered to either of them. Emily's breathing had become a little heavier. She used her legs to raise herself up and down on him, and the water splashed a little more with their movements. The lower half of her dress was soaked, clinging to her hips and legs as she raised herself up, then floating in the water and rubbing against them as she pushed downwards onto Mark's erection. The sensation of the hot water running all around their union heightened the pleasure.

Emily had been totally silent, but as she rode Mark harder and faster she started to moan. Mark realised she was getting close to her climax. He ran his hands over the wet dress to her tiny breasts. Her nipples stuck out through the thin material. He gently pinched the small hard beads, and suddenly Emily was coming. She dropped her head backwards and pushed down on his chest, scratching his skin and hurting his already bruised ribs. But Mark didn't complain.

Then Emily began grinding herself against him, his hardness buried deep inside her, filling her completely. She came for a second time from the

friction of her clit against his wet pubic bone. This time her cries were throaty, guttural. Water was splashing over the sides of the bath and onto the floor.

Gripping her by the hips and pulling her tiny frame forwards and backwards on his cock, Mark knew he was getting close to his own orgasm. He suddenly remembered his comments about unprotected sex when he'd seen Philippa's film with Spider.

Emily was watching his face.

"Emily, I'm going to come soon."

"I know." She speeded up the movements of her hips.

Mark let out a moan. "What I meant was I'm not wearing..."

Emily leaned closer until their foreheads were touching, holding his head in her hands. "Stop worrying and enjoy it. Let me feel you enjoy it. Let me feel you coming."

And she did. Emily rode him all the way to a wonderful release. Mark felt like his insides were turning into melted chocolate, pouring out of him and into her. He came for what seemed a very long time, Emily looking down at him. Then she kissed him gently all over his bruised face. He grew soft inside her. Emily lay against his chest, her dress completely soaked. They stayed like that until the water went cold.

* * * *

Mark was wearing Emily's dressing gown and she was in black leggings and a long, pale blue t-shirt. Their hair now dry, they'd eaten toast and marmalade. None of the eggs had survived their trip back from the shop.

"So, since I'm effectively unemployed, where would you recommend I visit when I go travelling?" she asked.

"I don't know what you want to do, but I'd say you should definitely see Australia and New Zealand. You can decide what else you want to see on the way there and back. You could try Thailand, Japan, or the States and Canada."

There was a loud bang on the door and they both jumped. Mark was uncomfortable about wearing a woman's bathrobe. He picked up his still-damp jeans off a radiator and put them on. Then he took off the robe and went to the door and opened it. Emily stood by his side.

There was nobody there. On the floor outside the door was a large brown envelope. Mark looked around and down the stairs but couldn't see anyone. He picked up the envelope and turned it over. There was nothing written on it. Mark passed the envelope to Emily.

"Maybe it's my wages and P45," she said.

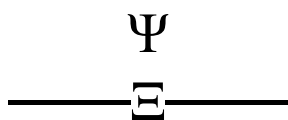
They went inside and closed the door. Emily took out a piece of A4 sized paper and looked at it with a puzzled expression. Then she passed it to Mark.

He saw it was a piece of photographic paper used in computer printers. Just off-centre on the paper was a photograph, obviously taken with a digital camera. Mark felt a cold sinking feeling in the pit of his stomach. The picture showed a brown-haired woman sitting in an armchair. She looked very worried and had obviously been crying shortly before the picture was taken. Two men stood either side of her. The top of the photograph cut them off at their shoulders, so they couldn't be recognised but each man had lowered his trousers, and they were both pointing their erections at the woman's face.

Emily came and stood by him. "I don't understand. Who is that?"

Mark's voice came out as little more than a whisper. "Her name's Lauren. She's my landlady."





Chapter Ten

Mal sat at the kitchen table eating a bacon roll. It was still before nine, but he'd had an extremely busy morning. At five-thirty he'd slipped out of bed and met Giff. They'd both driven to the south coast and met Louis. They'd paid the Frenchman and loaded the merchandise into three large vans.

When the two of them got back to Bristol over an hour ago, Giff had said he had something he needed to sort out so Mal had gone alone to meet the men who were handling storage and distribution of the merchandise.

"Hey babe," Honey said, kissing the top of his head as she entered the room. "How did it go this morning?"

Mal nodded, still chewing. Then he swallowed. "It went okay. The stuff's here and been divided up. Lacey's taking a third, I'm taking the rest. Louis has his money and will be well on his way back to France by now."

She nodded her approval as she opened the fridge door.

Mal watched as she poured herself some orange juice. "Sorry if I woke you this morning."

"No you're not." She turned round and flashed him a wicked smile. "And neither am I."

Mal checked his watch. Ray Lacey was due to arrive within the hour, and that didn't allow him time to get to Jimmy's and back. He needed to find out from Philippa just who this guy Hicks was, and what he wanted.

According to the woman Waltham questioned yesterday, Hicks spent a lot of time in Thailand last year. Waltham had warned Mal this could well mean he was connected to some drug trafficking gang.

This seemed to make sense to Mal. He was convinced someone was trying to muscle in on his business. They had somehow got word of his dealings with Ray Lacey. But he was determined that nobody would ruin this deal with Louis, nor any future ones. Deals like this one were going to set him up for life.

He'd started thinking about him and Honey spending a few years just taking it easy, buying somewhere on the Costa. Maybe they'd even consider starting a family.

Mal finished his sandwich. He stood up and stretched. He was still tired. "I'm going for a shower. If Giff calls, tell him to make sure he's here by ten."

* * * *

Jimmy had been awake for over an hour, listening to the soft breathing of the woman lying next to him. Her arm was around his waist, and one leg was draped over his. Her head was resting on his shoulder, her face hidden by her hair.

Jimmy closed his eyes and thought back over the last few hours. He and Philippa had stayed up late, watching rubbish on television and drinking wine. He knew she'd been through a lot over the last couple of days, and he'd tried to help her unwind. But just to be sure, he'd locked the deadlock on his flat door and hidden the key in his wardrobe. It was very late when they'd finally turned in, and Philippa had gone to her room looking fairly relaxed.

She'd come into his room in the early hours. He'd woken up as she slipped into his bed. When he'd realised she was naked he'd tried to tell her there was nothing he could do to stop Mal, but she just put her fingers to his lips. Her fingers then worked their way downwards, stroking his chest and then his stomach. By the time her hand reached his cock he'd been fully erect. Philippa had climbed on top and guided him inside her. She'd moved slowly and gently. Neither of them made a sound. Her breathing had gotten a little heavier, but Jimmy didn't think she'd had time to reach her orgasm before he'd felt himself coming, pouring into her.

In the cold light of day, Jimmy knew Philippa had just wanted company and to feel safe. But at the time, it seemed to him she was doing it for his benefit, just to give him pleasure. As she continued to sleep in his arms, Jimmy wondered just how badly Mal would hurt him if he were to let her go.

* * * *

Mark entered Moondust through the front door. He ignored the bar and headed straight towards the door marked 'private', which led to the stairs. The young man behind the bar appeared about to say something when he recognised Emily trailing behind him, struggling to keep up.

"We've just got to see Mal for a minute," Emily explained to the barman.

Mark barged into the room. All conversation immediately stopped, and everyone stared at him. He saw Mal sitting next to a big guy in a grey suit. Mark headed straight for him, but with his left eye almost completely closed due to the swelling, he didn't see Giff approaching until he was just two feet away, smirking.

Bending forwards slightly at the waist, Mark lunged at him. His forehead hit Giff full in the face, and there was a loud sound of crunching bone and cartilage. Giff's legs buckled and he slumped to the floor, his face covered in blood.

Two men standing against the far wall started to move towards Mark, but the big guy in the suit raised his finger, and they immediately stopped.

Mal got to his feet as Mark stopped right in front of him.

"I think we need to get something straight," Mark said. His voice was controlled, but there was a lot of anger there. "I don't know who you think I am, and I don't know what you think I have. But whatever it is, you're wrong. I do not have anything that belongs to you, and I don't really give a fuck if you ever find it or not."

Mark took out the photograph of Lauren with the two men, and held it up in front of Mal's face.

"And this woman doesn't know anything about whatever shit's going on down here." Mark lowered the sheet of paper and glared at Mal. "Now I am going to go home and phone her house every five minutes. If she doesn't answer her phone within the hour, I will be coming back here

with every policeman I can find. And if I can't convince any policemen to come with me, I will bring petrol and burn your fucking house down."

Without giving Mal the chance to reply, Mark turned and walked towards the door. As he passed the prostrate figure of Giff on the floor, Mark kicked him hard between the legs. Giff's whimpering was the only sound that Mark and Emily could hear as they descended the stairs. Nobody else in the room said a word.

* * * *

"I still cannot believe what you did back there."

Mark looked at Emily but didn't reply. In truth, he couldn't believe it either. They were standing in the kitchen of her flat. He picked up her mobile phone and re-dialled Lauren's number for the fifth time since they'd returned.

"Still no answer?"

He shook his head and put the phone down.

A loud bang on the door made them both jump and Mark ran to the door and yanked it open. There was another envelope on the floor, and Mark could hear somebody running down the stairs. He gave chase, taking the stairs three at a time. As he reached the lower flight he heard the entrance door bang. By the time Mark got outside, he was too late. A car was just turning the corner at the bottom of the road where he had been beaten up just a few hours earlier.

Mark was surprised when he saw Emily crying as he walked back into her flat, the piece of paper from the envelope in her hand. Mark walked towards her and took the sheet. It was the same type of photographic paper used for the earlier delivery. There were five photographs of varying sizes printed onto the A4 sheet. All of the pictures were of Lauren. In the first two pictures there were two men with her; in the third and fourth pictures there were three men present. The final picture was just Lauren.

None of the men could be recognised from any of the photographs. Grey circles had been strategically positioned over their faces with computer software before the pictures had been printed.

In the first picture, Lauren was struggling against two men. She had her hands crossed over her chest while one of the men pulled at her blouse. The second man stood behind her, reaching for her hands.

In the second picture, Lauren's blouse was ripped and hanging open, her bra and stomach visible. The man standing behind her now had her arms held behind her back. The man in front had one hand lifting up her skirt while his other hand was hidden between her legs.

Mark's hands shook with rage; a lump in his throat made it hard to breathe.

In the third picture there were three men. Lauren was now spread-eagled on a bed. One man held her arms over her head while another held her legs. Her skirt was pushed up around her waist and her blouse had been removed. Her bra was pushed up towards her chin, her breasts bare. Her black tights were ripped so both thighs were exposed. The third man was straddling Lauren. He was naked.

In the fourth, Lauren was lying on her stomach on the bed. Her skirt was still around her waist, her backside now completely exposed. One man knelt on the bed next to her, pulling back her hair so that her head was lifted up toward the camera. The other two men stood at the end of the bed, each pushing his erect penis into her face.

The look on Lauren's face was a mixture of fear and disgust, and Mark felt like he was going to be sick. Emily was standing next to him, examining the pictures with him. She was still sobbing.

The final picture was of Lauren sitting alone on the bed, her head down. The picture didn't show her eyes, but Mark could see the tear tracks on her cheeks. There were several splashes of semen on her neck and breasts. Lauren had not bothered trying to cover herself, even though her hands were no longer being restrained.

The room was silent. Mark still held the piece of paper in his hands, but he was no longer seeing the images. It wasn't until Emily passed him a tissue that he realised there were tears running down his cheeks. He closed his eyes and took several deep breaths.

Emily rubbed his arm. "She's more than just your landlady, isn't she?"

Mark nodded, but he needed several more deep breaths before he could speak. “We used to go out. For a long time...” He took more lungfuls of air. “For a long time, I thought we’d end up getting married. But I wanted to travel...” He laughed, and shook his head. “I wanted to see the world, but she wanted to settle down. You know the story.”

“Mark, I’m so, so sorry.”

He looked at Emily then. Her bright blue eyes sparkled with tears. “It’s not your fault. You’re as much a victim of this as I am—as Lauren is.”

Emily was shaking all over. Her face seemed to just crack, and the tears poured down her face once more. Mark wrapped his arms around her and held her tight while the sobs wracked her body. He knew this was the delayed reaction to what had almost happened to her last night. Seeing it happen to Lauren had obviously brought it all back, and the shock had finally hit her.

There was a quiet knock at the door. Emily and Mark stared at each other for a few seconds, and then they both made their way to the door. Mark opened the door a few inches and looked out. It was Honey. She was alone.

Mark opened the door wider to allow Emily to see their visitor. They all stood in silence for a few seconds, and then Emily invited Honey in.

Honey looked straight at Mark. “Before you ask, nobody sent me. Mal doesn’t know I’m here, and I think he’d go mad if he knew.”

He kept his voice firm. “So why are you here?”

Honey looked at him, and then at Emily. “I want to help you.”

“Well, you’re too fucking late.” Mark walked over and picked up the sheet of paper with the photographs. He shook it in front of Honey’s face. “You’re too late to help *her*.”

Honey looked at the pictures, and then back at Mark. “It’s not as bad as it looks.”

Mark took a step towards her. “How the fuck can you say that?” He had to use all his self-control to refrain from punching her.

Honey stepped back, obviously a little frightened. “I’m sorry. What I meant was—the men were told to make the photographs look bad. To upset you.”

“Upset me?” Mark shook the sheet of paper violently. “What about upsetting her? How would you like to be abducted by three strange men and gang-raped?”

“That’s not what happened.”

“*Look at the fucking photographs.*” Mark pushed the sheet into Honey’s face, making her stumble backwards.

Emily moved closer to Mark, trying to calm him down.

Honey regained her composure. “The woman wasn’t raped. Mal gave strict orders that she wasn’t to be hurt. But after your visit this morning, he phoned the men and told them to make it look like she had.”

Mark hesitated. He wanted so much to believe what he was being told.

Emily spoke. “Where’s she being held?”

Honey lowered her head. “I don’t know. Mal won’t tell me.”

The sheet of photographs had fallen to the floor. Mark bent and picked it up.

“Have you seen these pictures?”

Honey nodded. “The men who took the pictures e-mailed them to Mal and he printed them out. I saw them before they were delivered here.”

“And are you telling me the stuff on her chest is shampoo?”

Honey wouldn’t meet his eyes. “No.”

“But she didn’t know they weren’t going to rape her,” Emily said. “You can tell by her face. She’s terrified.”

Honey nodded. “I know, and I’m sorry.”

Mark took a breath and rubbed his face. The swelling gave it a strange shape.

“You said you wanted to help. How can you do that if you don’t know where she’s being held?”

“I know where Philippa is.”

“I don’t *care* where Philippa is.” Mark’s words surprised everyone, including him. “What I mean is—Philippa brought all this on herself. She made the films and she took them. Whatever happens to her is a consequence of her own actions.”

When Emily and Honey didn't contradict him, Mark went on. "Lauren is a totally innocent victim. She's done nothing wrong. She didn't make porno films or steal anything. She's the one who needs help."

Honey looked around the room. "Could we sit down for a few minutes?"

They walked to the suite. Honey and Emily sat on the settee, Mark took the armchair. He had a thought. "What am I supposed to have?"

Honey looked puzzled. "What do you mean?"

"Marsden thinks I've got something of his. In the bar last night when I brought him the films, he said something about a watch."

Honey nodded. "Several years ago—before I knew him—there was some trouble. Mal had a rival trying to interfere with his business activities, and they had a fight. The other man died. Mal stabbed him."

Mark's mouth dropped open.

"The other guy used to wear a pocket watch. It was very distinctive, and had his name engraved on it. Mal took it—as a kind of trophy, I suppose. He kept it in the safe in his office."

"And that's what's gone missing?"

Honey nodded.

"Is it very valuable, then?" Emily asked.

"Not as such. But the fact that Mal's fingerprints are all over it would probably give the police enough evidence to put together a case against him for murder. He was questioned about the man's death several times, apparently. But it never went to trial because there was no evidence. But with all the forensic tests they can do now, well—Mal's worried."

Mark was trying to think. "How would Philippa know about the watch?"

Honey shook her head. "I have no idea. But Mal's convinced you're involved in it. He thinks you're trying to ruin his deal with Ray Lacey."

Mark shook his head. "Who's Ray Lacey?"

"He was there this morning when you came by."

"And the deal with him is what?"

"Mal has just imported some stolen cigarettes."

“This is all about stolen fags?”

Honey nodded. “Don’t scoff. Have you any idea how much tax is added to a pack of cigarettes?”

“So he’s importing foreign cigarettes to sell here?”

“They’re not foreign. They’re the normal brands. But Ray Lacey has a contact in France who can steal them from the big duty-free shopping depots over there. They won’t be reported stolen for about a month, by which time they’ll have been sold.” Honey looked from Mark to Emily. “It’s a smart plan. Mal owns a part-share in a company that leases cigarette vending machines. It’s easier to sell cigarettes than illegal drugs. Nobody suspects anything’s wrong—especially if a big theft isn’t reported.”

Mark and Emily looked at each other. Mark wanted to see a flaw in the plan. “The government has banned smoking in all public buildings.”

Honey looked at him as if he were stupid. “And do you think that’s going to stop people buying cigarettes?”

Mark didn’t answer.

Honey changed the subject. “I’ve never seen anybody stand up to Mal like you did this morning.”

“Well, that was before I knew he was a killer.”

“You broke Giff’s nose and cheek-bone.”

Mark shrugged. “He had it coming. Or did Mal tell him to just make it look like it was rape, too?”

Honey frowned. “What do you mean?”

Mark nodded towards Emily. “Last night, when I was in the bar with you and Marsden, Giff was attacking Emily.”

Honey looked shocked and turned to Emily. “Where was this?”

“I was outside in the car. He found me and attacked me.” Emily looked down at her hands, which were clenched into tiny fists in her lap. “If Mark hadn’t come back when he did...”

Honey looked at Mark. “Is that when you were beaten up?”

Mark shook his head. “No, that was this morning.”

“Who did it?”

“Who do you think?”

“But Giff was with Mal. They went south.”

“It was Giff, with two of his friends.”

Honey shook her head. “Christ, what a mess.”

“Can I ask you a question?”

Honey nodded at him.

“Why does somebody who looks the way you do choose to stay with an evil bastard like Mal Marsden?”

Honey smiled. “He’s not always like this. He can be very charming when he wants to be. And he’s good fun to be around when he’s in the mood. All the parties at Moondust—nobody ever has to pay. He’s very generous.”

“He buys your clothes and jewellery?”

Honey laughed out loud. “Yes, he buys me anything I want. I suppose that makes me his whore in your eyes.”

You said it, love. That thought prompted more questions. “Do you attend the parties he throws?”

Honey nodded. “Of course I do.”

“And do you have sex with other men, or is it just the hired help like Philippa that gets to do that?”

Her face hardened. “Philippa wasn’t hired. She was invited to the parties, and she chose to join in with the fun and games. But the answer to your question is *no*. I do not have sex with anybody at the parties.”

There was an awkward silence.

“Well,” Honey finally said. “I just wanted to let you know that the pictures you received were misleading. I’m sorry I can’t help you with where she’s being held. And I don’t think you should go to the police, either. Not all of them are what they seem.”

“So what do you suggest we do?” Mark asked,

“Stay out of Mal’s way. Just for the rest of today.”

“And should I just try and ignore the fact that two women are being held against their will?”

Honey shook her head. “He’ll let them go soon. I promise.”



$$\Psi$$


Chapter Eleven

After Honey had gone, Mark and Emily sat in silence. Mark picked up the sheet of photographs and looked at it. The naked man on top of Lauren had a mark on his back. Mark looked closer. It was a scar, maybe two inches long. In another picture, one of the men had a series of Chinese letters tattooed on the inside of his left arm. Mark's mind was racing.

"Where did you put the other DVDs?"

"They're in the bedroom. Why?"

"I want to watch them. I'm hoping they were taken at these parties they had. I want to see if any of the men in the films have a scar or a tattoo like the men in these pictures."

Emily took the photographs and studied them, then went into the bedroom to get the DVDs.

Mark placed them side by side on the floor by the television. Each hand-written label showed a title that was a weak pun on an actual film: *Driving It Up Miss Daisy*, *The Prodfather*, and *Last Tango in Bristol*. Mark shook his head in disgust, and chose 'Tango' because it was the closest to him.

He placed the disc in the machine, picked up the remote and sat on the settee, Emily sitting next to him. In different circumstances, Mark may have joked about getting popcorn. He hit play.

For some reason the disc started mid-show, and the first image on the screen was a close up of a red-haired girl getting taken from behind as she leaned over a snooker table.

Mark hit 'stop' and then 'rewind'. "Don't you just hate it when there's no foreplay?"

Emily smiled and placed her hand on his arm, squeezing slightly.

Mark looked at her, shaking his head. "If someone had told me before yesterday that I'd be sitting next to a hot babe watching porno films..."

She laughed then, and he was relieved. She must know how upset he still was. His humour was a safety-valve—he used it as a release. The disc auto-started from the beginning.

Mark recognised the setting instantly; the film had been taken at Moondust. There were maybe thirty people in the room. Some stood in groups, others sat in leather chairs around tables. The shades were pulled down over all of the windows. Music was playing, and the conversation was hard to distinguish. The camera was being carried around the room, pausing on each group in turn, zooming in on random faces for a few seconds before moving on again.

Mark didn't recognise anybody in the film. There was no sign of Mal Marsden, Giff or Honey. And as yet there was no sign of Philippa.

Then something occurred to him. Mark pressed 'pause' and turned to Emily. "Before we get started, I think I'd like to know if I'm going to see you in any of these."

Emily looked at his face but seemed to pick up on the lack of accusation in his voice. "No. You won't be seeing me in any of the films."

Mark re-started the recording and they watched in silence. A few minutes of innocent footage passed where people were just having drinks and talking. At last Philippa came up on the screen. Her hair was longer, and she was wearing a jersey dress that came down to her knees. She stood in a group of five or six people, both men and women. But then the scene changed—the evening had evidently moved on. The camera scanned the room from a distance. People were in various states of undress. The camera settled on a couch where a well-dressed man was sitting between two attractive blonde women. The man's trousers were undone and the women were taking turns to fellate him.

After a couple of minutes of watching this action, the scene switched to a couple having sex doggy-style on the floor. The entire film was made up of a series of three or four minute scenes with different people featured. Philippa appeared towards the end of the film, lying on a table with a dark-haired girl on top of her. The pair were kissing, their naked breasts squashed flat together. A man approached the end of the table and stood between their legs. He held out his dick and leaned forwards, managing to enter one of the women. The camera moved around to the side

until the girl's faces could be seen. The reaction of the dark-haired girl suggested that she was the one getting pleased. As she closed her eyes and pushed her head back, Philippa kissed her on the face and neck. Then suddenly their roles changed. The dark-haired girl looked momentarily disappointed and Philippa let out a cry. Evidently the man had decided it was her turn.

While the camera was still in this position, someone else decided to get in on the action as well. A man's torso appeared on the screen behind the women, and he quickly dropped his trousers and introduced his dick between the women's faces. They eagerly set about licking and kissing it, and the dick was sucked by each woman in turn. The camera panned back, and the two men were seen to change places.

The last scene in the film was the red-haired girl on the snooker table. She was taken by three men, one after the other. For the first man she sat up on the edge of the table, the man standing between her legs. For the second, she was bent over the table. This was the image Mark and Emily had seen when they first put the film on. Finally, the girl was laid down in the middle of the table, and a man joined her there and entered her in the missionary position.

Mark jumped up from the seat and moved closer to the television. Then he pressed 'rewind' and watched it again. He pressed 'rewind' a second time, then froze the screen. He looked at Emily and pointed to the man on the snooker table. "Watch him there. I know the lighting's not good, but look at his back."

He pressed 'play' and leaned towards the screen, pointing with his finger. "Isn't that a scar?"

Emily leaned closer to the television "Yes... that looks like the same scar."

The man's face wasn't in view for about a minute, but then he turned his head to the side and his profile was clearly visible.

"Do you recognise him?" Mark was now watching Emily's face, rather than the screen.

Emily studied him closely. She was shaking her head. "I don't think so, but he does look familiar."

“If you don’t know him, how can he be familiar?”

“Stop badgering me!” She glared across at him, then sighed. “I’m sorry. What I mean is, I can’t tell you who that man is. But I *do* think I’ve seen him before. I just can’t say where or when.”

Mark nodded, and turned his attention back to the screen. The man with the scar pulled out of the girl just in time to send a jet of semen over her chest and stomach. This image was almost identical to the one shown in the photograph of Lauren. Mark bit his lip and stared. He wanted to hurt this man.

As he climbed off the table there was a perfectly clear view of his face.

“Wait, wait wait!” Emily leant forward. “He’s a driver. Lorries, I think. But he used to work as a bouncer at Venus when I was there.”

“Can you remember his name?”

Emily shook her head. “No.” She squeezed his hand. “But it’ll come to me, I’m sure.”

The television screen was now blank—the film had finished. ‘Miss Daisy’ was very similar to ‘Tango’, but when Mark saw Philippa chatting to a group of people around a table, he knew this film was much more recent than the others he’d watched. Her hairstyle was the same as she had it now. She was wearing a white vest-top with sparkling sequins sewn all over the front of it and a short blue skirt.

The real action finally started. There were couples, threesomes, and what looked like a free-for-all around a table. Mark and Emily watched all of this in silence, and after about twenty minutes the camera turned again and Philippa was suddenly centre screen. She was still wearing the short blue skirt and heeled sandals, but her vest had been discarded and she was topless. Her firm breasts were a perfect shape, the nipples dark and erect. She was sitting on a low stool and there were two men standing in front of her. Both men wore pale shirts, but nothing else. Philippa was slowly masturbating one of the men’s dicks. The other’s was buried in her mouth.

The camera moved position so that it showed the scene from behind and between the two men. Philippa would suck the men in turn, spending maybe twenty seconds on one before turning her attentions to the other. The

camera zoomed in and Mark studied Philippa's face. She didn't look at the camera, which several other guests had done when they realised they were being filmed. Philippa was looking into the face of whichever man was in her mouth. This went on for maybe two or three minutes before Mark saw Philippa's eyes narrow into a smile, and her head movements become a little more pronounced. He knew that the man had just reached his orgasm.

When the first man removed his dick from her mouth, Philippa held eye contact with him for a few seconds. She then turned her gaze towards the second man, but rather than taking him back into her mouth she pursed her lips and spat out the first man's ejaculate. A huge dribble of semen ran down her chin and dropped onto her chest. She was wearing a necklace—a thin silver chain with a pale green enamel tear-drop suspended inside a similar-shaped silver ring. The man's cum covered the necklace and then continued on its journey down between her breasts and out of view. Philippa took the second man into her mouth, and it seemed like only a matter of seconds before he too, was coming. Mark and Emily could hear his grunts and moans. Philippa finally released him from her mouth and then, looking directly at the camera, repeated her trick of letting the contents of her mouth spill down her chin.

Mark hit pause and looked at Emily. "Do you see the necklace she's wearing?"

Emily nodded.

"I bought that for Philippa last Christmas. This film was taken some time this year."

Emily looked back at the screen and sighed. "I know. I noticed Philippa's shoes—I've got an identical pair. We both bought them in the sales last January."

The rest of the footage was a series of sex acts involving most of the people in the room. But there was no sign of a man with a tattoo of Chinese writing on his arm. However, in one of the shots Mark noticed Philippa in the background. She was lying on a couch with her legs raised in the air. She was still wearing her shoes but her skirt had been removed. She was being fucked with force by a muscular man in a black shirt.

Mark had felt betrayed when he'd seen the film of Philippa with Spider, and he'd felt sick when he'd watched her performing the double blow job earlier in this film. But those feelings paled into insignificance compared to the loathing he felt when he realised that the man on top of Philippa was Giff.

Mark and Emily sat in silence for a few seconds before Mark recouped the energy to put the final film in. This was yet another party in Moondust. A younger looking Philippa was shown in an early scene, standing next to a tall guy in a white t-shirt.

"That's Jason," Emily said. "Philippa's brother."

"The one that died?"

The man was young and handsome. He had short-cropped fair hair, a square jaw and athletic build.

Emily leaned towards Mark and pressed 'pause' on the remote he was holding. "Mark, you know what you said yesterday, to the police?"

Mark looked at her. "What about?"

"About Jason being killed in a car crash?"

Mark nodded.

"That's not the truth."

"What do you mean? Philippa told me he was killed when his car hit a tree."

"That's not what happened. Jason took an overdose. He committed suicide."

Mark was silent. He could understand why Philippa wouldn't want people to know the truth about her brother's death. Mark looked back at the screen and suddenly felt desperately sorry for Philippa. What must it have felt like for her when this handsome young man took his own life?

Mark couldn't think of anything to say, so he restarted the film, which followed the same format as the others shot at Moondust; dressed people chatting followed by half-dressed people fucking. Philippa featured as a participant in an orgy scene two-thirds of the way through the film, at one stage performing oral sex on a dark-haired girl while being taken from behind by a man with a beard. And then the two women changed places and

a second man joined the fun, introducing his dick into Philippa's mouth. Mark lost count of the number of men and women that Philippa sucked and fucked during the next fifteen minutes. The camera moved on to several other people, but by now whatever they were doing to each other didn't interest him—he was way past caring. All he looked for was a man with a tattoo of Chinese writing, who still didn't appear. Either he was not one of the 'in-crowd,' or he'd had his arm illustrated sometime after these films were taken.

Mark realised there seemed to be a commotion happening somewhere out of shot. The image became unsteady as the cameraman walked towards a crowd of people. There was a woman shouting, and others laughing. And then the camera zoomed in, and it showed a middle-aged man with his trousers around his ankles. He'd obviously been caught bugging the man on his hands and knees, who was facing the opposite direction. The woman shouted something else, and Mark realised it was Philippa's voice. The man on the floor turned around. Mark and Emily both gasped when they saw it was Jason. He looked devastated, with tears running down his cheeks. As the camera turned back to the room, there was a crowd of people staring with amused faces. But to the left of the screen, Philippa could be seen picking up her clothes from a chair and storming off.

Mark stopped the film and the two of them sat in silence for several minutes. The final scene had stunned them both. If Emily hadn't told Mark the truth about Jason's death, perhaps he wouldn't have seen this as such a big deal. But now that Mark knew, the implications were massive.

Emily broke the silence. "I suspect this was the reason why Fizz took the DVDs. I had no idea about Jason being at a party, and I never heard about all that we've just seen. I don't know what she said to him after the party, or how long it was after the party that he died. But I *do* know she hasn't spoken to her parents since his funeral."

Mark sat and tried to take it all in. Could it be true that Jason had committed suicide as a result of his sister not approving of his sexuality? Surely not. As the films had shown, Philippa was far from a perfect role model. In fact, she'd taken part in gay sex at the very same party as Jason had.

Mark shook his head and stood up. “Well, whatever made Jason kill himself isn’t going to change things for Lauren.”

“I know.” Emily breathed out slowly and stared at the far wall. “I’m still trying to remember if Philippa had said anything when Jason died. Anything that hinted this had happened.”

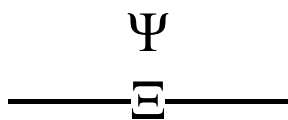
Mark gave her a moment, then crouched down next to her. “Emily.”

“Sorry?”

“I really need you to remember who the guy with the scar is. Or at least try and find out his name.”

Emily was nodding, but then her eyes sparked. “He went out with one of the dancers for a while. I can phone her and get his name. And maybe she’ll know his address.”





Chapter Twelve

Mal's mobile rang. He checked the caller ID—unknown number.
“Yeah?”

“Mal, it's me.”

“Honey? Where are you? And where's your own phone? I thought you were only going to be half an hour.”

“I thought so, too. But somebody had other ideas.”

“What do you mean? Who had other ideas?”

“When I parked my car there were two men waiting for me.”

“What men? Where are you?”

“They brought me to a house somewhere. I don't know where it is.”

“Who are they? Put them on the phone.”

“They don't want to speak to you. They gave me a message for you.”

“What fucking message?”

“They said to tell you that your shipment from France is now theirs.”

“Like fucking hell it is. Put the cunts on the phone, and I'll tell them just what they're going to get from me.”

“Mal, they've taken my clothes.”

“*What?* What do you mean they've taken your clothes? What are you wearing now?”

“Nothing. Well, just my shoes. He said he liked my shoes, so I had to keep them on.”

“Who said that? Who is he? Describe him.”

“Big, white, mid-forties. Short grey hair. His hands are huge; they look like bunches of bananas. He wears sovereign rings on most fingers.”

“Is he there with you now?”

“Yes.”

“Tell him I’m going to cut his fat fucking fingers off and shove them down his throat.”

“He’s made me kneel on a table.”

“*What?*”

“I’m on my hands and knees on a coffee table in the middle of the room.”

“And where’s he?”

“He’s walking around, looking at me.”

“What about the other one? You said there were two men.”

“He’s not here now. He’s gone.”

“So you’re naked on the table?”

“Yes, except for my shoes. And I’ve got a hands-free phone clipped to my ear.”

“Honey, ask the man what he wants. Tell him I can sort this out.”

“He said he already has what he wants. He has your cigarettes, and he has me.”

“Tell him that I’m going to find him and I’m going to...”

“Mal, he’s stroking my backside.”

“Honey, listen. Tell the man that he can keep the cigarettes, but if he touches you, I’ll fucking...”

“Ah. His fingers are inside me. They’re huge, but he’s not being too rough.”

“Honey, don’t let him do this. Don’t let him...”

“Ow, oh. Now he’s just put another finger up my backside. Ooh.”

“Honey. Close your mind. Don’t think about it. Just think about something else. Anything. Forget what’s going on, just protect your mind and think about anything.”

“He’s taken his fingers out. He’s walking around. He’s standing in front of me. Mal, he’s taking his cock out of his trousers.”

“I swear to God that I’m going to fucking kill him if he...”

“Ugh... Ugh... Mmm...”

“Honey, bite him. Bite his fucking dick off.”

“Mmm... Ugh... Mmm.”

“*Leave her alone you bastard!*”

“Mal, he’s walking around me again. His cock’s huge. I thought I was going to choke.”

“Honey, shout for help. Scream at the top of your voice—somebody will hear you and call the police.”

“Oh. Oh God. Mal, oh Mal. He’s... he’s.... Oh, Mal, he’s fucking me. *Christ* he’s big.”

“Honey, I swear on my life that I will find this mother-fucker and I will cut him into small pieces.”

“God, his cock’s huge, but he’s being so gentle. He’s fucking me very slowly, and I can feel him sliding all the way into me, right up to the floor of my womb. And then he’s sliding it almost all the way out. He must be ten inches long, and it’s *so thick*.”

“Honey. Honey, please baby, scream for help.”

“Mal, it’s so, so... Oh. Oh. Oh God, Mal. Mal, I’m going to come.”

“*What?* You can’t fucking-well tell me that you’re...”

“Oh, Oh, Yes. Fuck me! Fuck me and don’t stop. Oh God, yes. Just keep fucking me like this. Oh, ooh, ooh.”

“Honey! What the hell do you think you’re fucking playing at?”

“Mal, he’s coming now. I can feel him coming inside me. I can feel the pulse in his cock as he’s coming. Wow, he’s still coming, I can feel the wet warmth inside my—oh God, Mal. I’m going to come again. Oh. Ooh yes, I’m coming again!”

Mal’s loosened his grip on the phone as the realisation of what was happening washed over him. He dropped slowly into his chair.

“Mal, are you still there?”

“I’m here.”

“He’s taken his cock out of me now, and I can feel his stuff running down my legs. Well, it may not all be his stuff. I got pretty wet myself.”

“Honey, what are you doing?”

“I’m leaving you. I’m going to live somewhere where you won’t find me. And I’ve got the watch from the safe. If I hear that you’re looking for me, the watch will be anonymously delivered to the police. Do you understand?”

“Why are you doing this?”

“Because I can. You’re never going to rise above what you are now. But I want more, and I’m going to get it. I’m moving up in the world, Mal. I’m going to visit all sorts of fantastic countries and meet loads of interesting people. And best of all, I can get a huge cock to fuck me whenever I want it.”

“You fucking... little... bitch.”

The line went dead, and Mal threw his phone at the wall.

* * * *

Emily ran out of her bedroom when she’d finished making her phone calls. “His name’s Dennis Allman and I got his phone number. I dialled it to see if he answered, and I got his flatmate. He told me that Dennis was on a fishing trip in Somerset with some friends.”

Mark looked dejected. “Somerset? How are we going to find him in Somerset?”

“His flatmate said he’d gone with his friend Jamie.” Emily smiled, relieved to have some news to report. “I know Jamie—he worked at the bar with me. I also know he owns a cottage in Minehead, which is in Somerset.”

“Do you have the address?”

“No, but I don’t think I’ll need it. I’ve been there a couple of times before.” She bit her lip, not particularly keen on disclosing the circumstances. “Mark, Fizz used to go out with Jamie.”

Mark stared at her open-mouthed. “Philippa used to go out with one of the men in the photographs with Lauren?”

Emily nodded.

Mark snatched up his coat. “Come on, let’s go and get her out of there.”

* * * *

It took almost ninety minutes to complete the sixty five-mile journey. When they arrived in the town, Mark parked outside one of the few beach shops that were still open this late in the year. Buckets and spades dangled from hooks attached to the shop’s awning.

“I just want to buy a couple of things,” he said, leaving Emily in the car looking confused.

Inside the shop, Mark picked up a rounders bat. It was effectively a short wooden baseball bat—maybe fifteen inches long and two and a half inches at its widest point. Mark placed it on the counter. It occurred to Mark that it would seem a strange purchase for a man with a badly bruised face, but the shop owner didn’t seem to care.

He then saw a small telescope in a glass case near the window. It was only about four inches long, but when he held the telescope to his only open eye, Mark could clearly make out the faces of people walking on the pavement about seventy yards away. He placed the telescope with the bat.

Mark scoured the shelves. He needed another purchase, but he didn’t know exactly what he wanted. He would have the bat in his right hand, but he wanted something for his left. He was thinking maybe an aerosol of hair-spray, that kind of thing. But then Mark saw the perfect item on a shelf with tins of cycle oil—WD40. Mark had used the lubricant many times when working on his car and knew the nozzle was perfect for firing a thin jet of solvent over a distance of two to three feet.

He paid up, got back to the car, and started the engine. “Which way do I go from here?”

Emily pointed straight ahead. “We need to go through town, and then we take a right turn just after a garage.”

They made their way through the town. Although it was a cold Tuesday in November, there were still quite a few people walking about the

shops. They found the turning easily enough, and Emily said she remembered that the cottage was about half a mile down this road.

“Is it isolated from all the other houses?” Mark asked.

Emily shook her head. “Not really. It’s detached, and has a garden. But there are other houses around it. Most of them are just summer homes, so there may not be many people about.”

Mark nodded. He was trying to come up with a plan of action. He didn’t want to get Emily involved if he could help it, but the fact that she knew at least two of the men could work to his advantage.

“It’s just up here on the left. That’s it, I think.” Emily was looking at the houses on either side, as if not entirely certain.

“Are you sure?”

She nodded. “Yes. It’s definitely that one.”

Mark drove slowly past the house, and parked his car around the next corner, out of view.

“What’s the plan, then?” Emily asked.

Mark pulled out the telescope. “I thought we could find somewhere to watch the house from. I’d like to have an idea of how many men are there before I go in.”

Emily nodded. “And then you’re going to bash them with the bat.” She held up the WD40 and read the label. “Is this in case they have her chained to a chair with a rusty padlock?”

Mark took the spray-can out of her hand. “Why don’t you just leave the jokes to someone with a sense of humour?”

Emily laughed, but Mark could see how scared she really was.

“I think you should stay here.”

Emily looked suddenly serious. “No chance. I’m coming with you. Remember what happened the last time you left me in your car?”

Mark nodded. “Okay. Come on.” He placed the bat inside the large inner pocket of his jacket, and put the aerosol in a side pocket.

They got out of the car and walked back towards the corner. Looking around, Mark noticed there was a small park on the other side of the road. It was completely empty. Mark indicated to Emily that they should

go for a walk around the park, and she moved closer to him. They held hands as they walked through the gate, trying to look like two people just spending time together. There were several benches along the pathway, and Mark chose one partly hidden by a bush. Sitting down, he had a clear view of the front of the cottage.

It was a small rendered building, with a window either side of the front door, and two windows set into the roof. It had probably been built as a bungalow, and then had the loft converted into bedrooms at a later date. There was a dark green VW Polo parked in the drive.

Mark took out the telescope and studied the windows—there was no sign of life inside.

Emily leaned against him. “Do you think they’ll have guns?”

Mark lowered the telescope and stared at her. He suddenly felt sick. The possibility of them being armed had never occurred to him. As far as he knew, he’d never met anyone who owned a gun.

“I don’t think they will,” she said. “But I just thought we should consider it.”

“Do Mal Marsden’s people usually go around armed?”

Emily shrugged. “Not that I’ve ever seen.”

Just then, someone came out of the house. Mark passed the telescope to Emily. “Who’s that?”

Emily peered through the eye-glass. “That’s Jamie. So it is this house.”

Mark watched as the Polo reversed onto the road and drove back towards town. “Okay, this could be a good time to make our move. There’s one less of them now.”

“Actually, I may have a plan.”

Mark looked at Emily. “Oh? And what’s that?”

“I know Jamie. What if I go to the door and say I was in the area and I called to see Jamie? Dennis knows I know him, so he won’t suspect me. You can get in through the back and sneak Lauren out while I talk to the guys.”

Mark nearly laughed at the impracticality of that. “Sounds like a top plan. However, there are a couple of flaws. Firstly, I can’t break in anywhere and do it quietly. I’m not a trained burglar. Secondly, what if Mal’s told them you’re helping me?”

Emily frowned. “Oh, yes. Sorry, I never thought of that.”

She looked so crushed he felt a little mean. Mark put his hands on either side of her face and smiled. “But it has the makings of a good plan.”

They started to walk towards the cottage, and Mark made a decision. “What I think we should try is... you knock on the door, and when someone answers, I’ll jump them. Hopefully that should only leave one man left guarding Lauren.

Emily looked worried. “Will that work?”

Mark shrugged. “It works on the telly.”

As they made their way up the drive, Mark watched the windows. He saw no sign of any movement at all, but he couldn’t be sure the occupants hadn’t seen them approach. Emily stood by the front door and Mark stood to one side, out of sight. He checked all around—there was nobody about on the road or in any of the gardens nearby.

Mark held the bat in his right hand and the WD40 in his left. He nodded at Emily, and she knocked on the door. Nobody answered. Emily waited for over thirty seconds, and then she knocked again. Mark wondered if the occupants would come out of a back door and see him. He was just beginning to worry when the door opened.

“Hi. Is Jamie in?” Emily asked in a polite voice.

Just as the man started to answer, Mark leapt in front of Emily and sprayed the solvent into his face. The man let out a scream and put his hands up to his eyes. Mark brought the bat down with force onto the man’s left forearm, which was tattooed with Chinese letters. The guy let out another scream of pain as Mark pushed past him, into the house. Mark found himself in a small hallway, with doors leading off to the left and right. At the end of the hallway there was another door on the left, and a staircase leading off to the right.

Another man came through the door opposite the stairs, looking startled. It was Dennis, the scarred man from the video. Mark quickly

covered the short distance between them and slammed the bat down onto his shoulder. Dennis let out a cry of pain as his left arm hung uselessly at his side. Mark had broken his collarbone.

Glancing back to make sure the first man was still incapacitated, Mark saw he was crawling along the hall floor, his eyes still shut, tattooed arm obviously broken. He glanced at Emily before running up the stairs, taking them two at a time. He burst through the first door he came to, and there was Lauren. She was sitting on the bed in her skirt and a t-shirt that was much too big for her. She looked terrified. When she saw Mark, she burst into tears.

He pulled her to her feet, wrapped his arms around her and held her so tightly that he was probably hurting her.

“Mark, what have you done? I’ve been worried sick.”

Mark couldn’t let her go. “I haven’t done anything, and *I’m* the one who’s been worried sick. What have they done to you?”

Lauren pulled away. She looked into his battered face. “Are you all right? The police told me you were involved in some drug smuggling.”

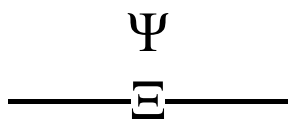
Mark was just about to answer when Emily appeared at the door. Lauren looked at her, and then back at Mark.

“This is Emily. She’s helped me find you. Come on, let’s get out of here.”

Lauren’s feet were bare. She found her shoes and put them on. Her coat was hanging on the back of a chair. On the floor were the tattered remains of her blouse and tights.

They made their way down the stairs. Dennis and the tattooed man were sitting on the hall carpet, leaning against the wall. Both looked pale. Neither of them spoke as Mark dragged Lauren past them. Emily closed the door behind them as they left. They ran to the car, and Emily helped Lauren into the back seat. Mark turned the car around and headed back towards town.





Chapter Thirteen

The journey back to Bristol was done in relative silence, Lauren in the back seat and Emily next to Mark in the front. When they reached the city she gave directions to her flat. Mark pulled his car up outside the door.

“Fancy a coffee or anything?”

Mark glanced back at Lauren, then shook his head. “No, I think we’d both prefer to get back home, thanks.”

Emily nodded. “Yeah, course.” She gave Mark a half-smile, feeling a little awkward. She knew she probably wouldn’t see him again.

As she made to reach the door handle, Mark leaned over and squeezed her hands. “Thank you. You took a big risk helping me, and I’m really grateful. You made the difference between finding her and not finding her. You know that.”

Emily blinked the tears from her eyes. She squeezed his hand back and then climbed out of the car. She wondered briefly how their relationship might have developed if they’d met under different circumstances.

When Emily walked through her flat door, Philippa got up from the settee and walked towards her. Emily wanted to rage and rant, but was too shocked at how awful Philippa looked. The hair colour was the least of the changes. Philippa’s eyes were sunken, red-rimmed and bloodshot. Her nose was red, her lip split and swollen. But worst of all, she looked broken *mentally*—a shadow of the girl Emily had been out partying with just a few nights ago. When Emily saw the tears in Philippa’s eyes she just held her arms open. Philippa rushed to her and they embraced, both girls now crying.

Emily finally pulled back a little and looked into Philippa’s eyes. “Tell me what’s happened and where you’ve been.”

Philippa sniffled and wiped her nose on her sleeve. She nodded in the direction of the DVDs in a pile by the television. “The last time I was down here I got talking to Honey. I was a bit drunk, and I mentioned that I

wanted to put all of the parties and stuff behind me. She offered to help me get back all the DVDs that I was in. There's one..." She took a few deep breaths but couldn't continue.

Emily stroked her arms. "Is it the one with Jason?"

Philippa's face crumbled and the tears flowed freely again.

Emily held her close. "It's okay, I know. Where did you go? I know you left those at the Sports Hall and wrote to Mark. What happened after that?"

Philippa took a few deep breaths, composed herself a little. "Erm, let me think. I spent Saturday night in a B&B, and on Sunday took a taxi to Chippenham. They found me on the train."

"Who found you?"

"Jimmy."

"The fucking weasel—"

"He's alright, really. He tried to help me as much as he could. But you know Mal."

"Yeah. I *used* to work for him."

"What? Oh, Em, I'm so sorry for getting you—"

"Don't worry about it. It was time to leave anyway. Were you in Moondust?"

"No. I was kept at Jimmy's flat while Mal went to France for something. But he did call to say hello..."

Emily knew Philippa was trying to put on a brave face, but she failed miserably. She started shaking again.

"I... I... thought he was going to..."

Emily held her close again, comforting her.

When Philippa finally got herself under control she told Emily about Mal's reaction on finding the locker empty.

Although she didn't want to pile any more pressure on Philippa, Emily knew she had to tell her about who else had suffered as a result of her actions.

"I think it was unfair to involve Mark," she said. "He's had a really bad time of it."

Philippa looked concerned. “Why, did he watch the films?”

“What? Yeah, but that’s not what I mean. He was badly beaten up by Giff and some others, but his landlady was kidnapped. They made Mark think they’d raped her.”

“*What?*” Philippa stared open-mouthed.

“And Giff tried to rape me. If it hadn’t been for Mark, he would have done.”

“God, I can’t believe it. I’m so sorry. What about Lauren? Where’s she?”

“Mark got her back. She was held at Jamie’s cottage in Minehead.”

Philippa closed her eyes and hung her head. “Honey said the discs wouldn’t be missed. She’d even sorted out the ones I needed and left them in a bin liner on a shelf in Mal’s office for me. I was in and out in less than ten seconds.”

“How did you get into the safe for the watch?”

Philippa frowned. “What watch?”

“The watch you took from Mal’s office.”

Philippa shook her head, confused. “The only thing I took from Mal’s office was those four DVDs. I didn’t take a watch.”

Emily stared at her for a few seconds and knew immediately she was telling the truth. “So how did you get away?”

“Mal phoned Jimmy a couple of hours ago, told him to let me go. Apparently I wasn’t a problem any more. Jimmy drove me here.”

Emily wondered what had happened to make Mal not care about Philippa or the watch any more. But whatever the reason, one thing was sure—her time in Bristol was coming to an end.

“I’ve decided it’d be best if I got out of town, as they say in the cowboy films.”

Philippa nodded. “Yeah, I think my time round here is over, too.”

Emily softened her voice. “Hey, I think it’s important that you go and see your parents. You need to build bridges, because you’re all they’ve got left.”

Philippa's tears started to flow again, and Emily guided her back to the settee and went to get a bottle of wine and a couple of glasses.

* * * *

After Emily left, Lauren got into the front seat. Once Mark had found his way to the motorway, Lauren started to ask questions.

"So, when did all of this start?"

Mark glanced over at her. "For me or Philippa?"

"Both, I suppose."

"I think it started for Philippa pretty soon after she first went to Uni. She's been part of that seedy crowd for years."

"The other guy you thought she was seeing?"

Mark snorted. "I think another guy would have been much easier thing to accept. It was more of a lifestyle thing." He explained about the films he'd seen, and the fact that Philippa had taken the DVDs and something else from a gangster-type character.

"So how did you get involved?"

Mark told her about Philippa's letter, the key, and the trip to find the pub where Emily worked.

"So was Emily mixed up in it all, too?"

Mark shook his head. "No, she was just a friend of Philippa's. But she ended up getting dragged into it all as well."

"She seems nice."

Mark nodded. "Yeah, she is."

He described how she'd been attacked by Giff, and about her helping him after he'd been beaten up. He didn't mention the part about him and Emily making love in her bath.

"If it wasn't for her, we'd never have found out where you were being held. And as a result of her helping me, she's lost her job, too."

Lauren was quiet while Mark had to negotiate yet more road-works and traffic jams.

Mark glanced over at her again. “What about you? What was the first you heard about it?”

“I worked late last night, and when I got home there was a police car parked outside. The detective told me you were suspected of being involved in some drug trafficking. As soon as I mentioned you’d been to Thailand they said it all made sense. He asked if I’d mind accompanying him to Bristol to help sort it out with some Customs and Excise officers. So of course I went with him.”

“What was the policeman’s name, can you remember?”

Lauren frowned. “Walton, or something like that.”

Mark nodded. “Waltham. I’m pretty sure he’s a bent copper. He came to see me at Emily’s house earlier in the day. I showed him the letter Philippa had sent, and I think he kept the envelope. He’d have been able to find out who else lived at the address easily enough.”

“He knew my name. I just assumed you’d asked him to come and get me to help prove your innocence.”

Mark reached over and held her hand.

Lauren took another breath. “When he handed me over to the Customs and Excise officers, it just seemed *wrong*. He’d questioned me in the car, and then we met the other guys on a car park. I never went near a police station.”

“I’m really sorry you got dragged into all of this. It must have been a nightmare.”

Lauren ran her fingers gently over the bruising on his face as he drove. “I think you’ve had a much worse time of it. Realistically, all that happened to me was that a couple of guys jerked off over my boobs. I’ve had worse than that on one night stands—don’t forget I actually married a guy I hardly knew. As soon as it was over, they apologised. They said the photos were going to be used to make you name your accomplices.”

Mark shook his head. “The lying bastards.”

“That was the worst part for me, thinking that you’d been lying to me ever since you’d got back from your travels.”

* * * *

It was dark by the time they arrived home. Mark realised he hadn't eaten for a long time, and suggested he got them both a take-away. When he got back twenty-five minutes later, Lauren was showered and changed into leggings and a t-shirt. They sat side by side on the couch and ate in relative silence with their trays on their knees.

Lauren finished first and put her tray on the floor. She wiped her mouth with a serviette. "So where's Philippa now?"

Mark looked at her and shrugged. "I don't know. After I received the photos of you, my focus seemed to change. I realised..." He shook his head and put his own tray down.

"You realised what?"

Mark looked at her. Her eyes were moving very slightly as she shifted her focus between his left and right eye. She had great eyes.

"I realised that I didn't think finding Philippa was important any more. It was you I needed to find."

Lauren put her hand in his.

Mark gave a half smile. "It was you I needed. It's always been you."

Lauren leaned over and kissed him gently on the lips. Mark slipped his fingers into her hair and held her head, returning the kiss.

Lauren pulled her head back a little, smiled, and rubbed her nose against his. "I don't want to sleep alone tonight."

Mark stood up and pulled her to her feet. They left the debris from their meal on the lounge floor, turned the lights off and went upstairs. Lauren helped Mark out of his clothes, taking time to stroke all the bruises now showing on his ribs. They lay in bed and held each other close until they both fell asleep.

Mark awoke to the very pleasant feeling of being gently stroked on his stomach. He opened his eyes and saw Lauren smiling at him.

"Good morning." She sounded happy.

Mark placed his hand on her hip. "Hello, you."

Lauren slid her hand down and gripped his cock—he was already rock hard. As she climbed on top of him he fed himself inside her. She closed her eyes and exhaled, but didn't move.

He held her close, kissed her cheek, smelled her hair. She felt warm, soft, familiar. She felt wonderful. Finally Lauren started to move on him, very slowly. He stroked her back, caressed her bum, traced his fingertips along the backs of her thighs. She kept up the same rhythm, the only sound their breathing. After what felt like a long time, Lauren's breathing became ragged. Her movements got a little more urgent, and then she let out a long, low groan, and grew still.

Mark held her close and felt her heart beating against his chest. He kissed her face and stroked her back.

Finally she opened her eyes and looked at him. "Mmm, I'd forgotten what we were like together."

Mark smiled. "I hadn't."

Lauren laughed and kissed his nose. "Well, I'm sorted, thanks."

"I noticed."

Lauren raised her eyebrows, a half-smile on her face. Mark rolled them over until he was on top. Her legs slipped round the back of his, and he raised himself up on his arms. He watched her face as he started to fuck her, and she slid her arms around his waist, moving against him. It seemed familiar and right. He increased the intensity of his thrusts, and she pulled her head up off the pillow, sinking her teeth into his shoulder. He let out a sigh, and they both knew he was getting close.

Lauren lay back on the bed and placed her hands on either side of his face. They stared into each other's eyes as Mark suddenly went still. He flooded her. Lauren let out little whimpers, and he felt her contracting around him as she came again. He pushed into her a few more times until they were both spent, and then he lowered himself down and they kissed deeply.

They lay together for another ten minutes, then took a shower together. Lauren phoned into work to explain her absence, although Mark didn't hear what excuse she'd made up. Mark then phoned his boss to say he'd be taking the rest of the week off. He said he'd take it as holiday, but

when he explained he'd been mugged, his boss told him to take it as sick leave.

Mark and Lauren spent the rest of the day just sitting around in a comfortable silence. Mark was happy to take this as slowly as he needed to. He no longer felt the need to be anywhere else.

* * * *

Mal found a booth near the back of the bar and ordered a large whisky. He was almost thirty minutes early for his meeting, so he took out his new phone and called the estate agent. They'd managed to sell Venus within the first twenty-four hours of it being on the market, and Galaxy was also attracting quite a bit of interest. Mal hadn't visited either of the clubs lately, and he'd needed to free up some cash after the fiasco with the shipment from France.

He knew he'd been double-crossed, but he wasn't sure exactly how many people had been involved. The one thing he *was* sure about was that Mal Marsden didn't take that sort of thing without kicking back. Honey had told him he was never going to rise above what he was now. *I'll show the bitch exactly what I am*. Everything Mal had achieved was a result of his own attributes—hunger and tenacity. He wasn't going to roll over and play the wounded dog simply because some fucking bimbo wanted to see the world.

Mal downed his drink in one and ordered the same again. He sat in gloomy silence for a few more minutes, and then a guy in a blue shirt and jeans who'd been sitting at the bar since his arrival slid off his stool and approached his table.

"I believe you're here to see me."

Mal peered up at him. The guy looked like someone who worked behind a shop counter. "Are you Newall?"

The guy slid into the seat opposite Mal. "What exactly is it that you need?"

"I've been messed about and made a fool of. I want the people responsible to pay for it."

Newall showed completely no emotion in his face. “The question is, are you willing to pay for it?”

Mal glared hard into Newall’s eyes. “Oh yes. I’ll be happy to pay whatever it takes.”

Newall held eye contact for a few seconds, then nodded and leaned back in the seat. “In that case, I’ll have an espresso while you tell me exactly what you want.”

When the waitress brought Mal’s drink he ordered the coffee for Newall. Then he pulled a couple of photographs from his jacket pocket and placed them on the table. He tapped the face of the one showing a man. “I want him dead. I don’t care how it happens, and I don’t need him to know who was behind it. I never liked the Bond films where the villain needs to explain everything. I don’t care if he knows it’s coming or not. I just want him dead.”

Newall gave a very slight nod, and Mal saw his eyes wander over to the picture of Honey. It had been taken during a promotional night at Moondust. She was wearing a figure-hugging white silk dress with a halter neck. She looked like a film star—glamorous and beautiful.

“This one...” Mal paused, trying to think of the right words. “This one, she’s in possession of something that could be harmful to me, so I have to be a little bit careful. I can’t afford for her to die, because I suspect she’s left instructions for that possession to be revealed if that were to happen.”

Newall was watching his face, no longer interested in looking at the picture.

“However, I want her to lose the ability to use her looks to get whatever she wants. She’s spent her life getting what she wants using those perfect features, that fabulous body, and all the wonderful things she can do with it. I want you to make it so she can’t do that any more.”

Newall gave a tiny nod. Mal wondered briefly if Newall would consider having fun with her before he carried out his orders, but he didn’t care either way.

“All you need to do is to make sure she thinks you were after the guy, and that she was just in the wrong place at the wrong time.”

Newall stared back for a few seconds, then gave another brief nod. Then he slipped a piece of paper from his pocket onto the table. It showed an account number and a sort code.

“Pay thirty grand into that account by the end of the day. I’ll send you the evidence to show the job’s been done, and I’ll expect another payment of the same amount on that day.”

“Fair enough.” Mal emptied his drink, picked up the slip of paper and walked from the booth, leaving Newall there with the two photographs.

* * * *

Honey sat on a yacht anchored off the coast of Bermuda. Her skin was covered in a thin sheen of suntan oil, her sunglasses pushed up onto the top of her head. Smiling at the man in the deck-chair opposite her, she put the red straw in her mouth seductively and took another sip from her ice-cold cocktail. “What are we doing tonight?”

“Well, if you carry on teasing me like that—you’re going to get shagged.”

Honey laughed. “Of course I am. But I meant what are we doing afterwards?”

“Oh, I think we can find something to do on this island. And if not, we’ll just sail on to the next one.”

She smiled again, lifting her leg up and rubbing his thick white thigh with her dainty brown foot. She noticed the bulge in his shorts. “Maybe I should try and relieve some of the swelling you seem to have?”

And with that she slid onto the deck and crawled towards him. The only sounds were that of the sea lapping against the side of the boat, and the slurping of her mouth around his cock.

Ray Lacey smiled and closed his eyes.

The feeling of cold metal against her cheek made Honey open her eyes. A gun. Before she had a chance to move, the man holding the gun fired. The bullet entered through her left cheek, missed her tongue

completely, but shattered two of the lower-right teeth, taking out most her right cheek.

The bullet had severed Ray Lacey's erect cock completely. Blood spurted out with such force that Honey's throat was filled before she'd hit the deck.

She felt like her face was on fire from the pain, and her ears were still ringing from the sound of the shot. She kept her eyes closed tightly, expecting to be killed at any moment. But after several seconds, when nothing had happened, she opened her eyes. Ray Lacey's body was less than three feet away. He was clearly dead, blood oozing from his groin now his pulse had stopped.

The man who had held the gun was now holding a mobile phone and looking out to sea. He walked across the deck and stood over Lacey. He held up his phone and took several pictures of his body. Then he turned and walked over and crouched down by her.

"I don't know if you understand English, but I'm afraid you were in the wrong place at the wrong time." He nodded towards Lacey's body. "But you really should tell your pimp to find you a better class of client."

Honey saw a speedboat heading towards the yacht just before she passed out.

* * * *

The skipper of a fishing boat boarded what he thought was a deserted yacht. On the deck he discovered the blood-soaked body of a man. Inside the cabin was a woman. The flesh on one side of her face appeared to have been ripped off, and she was almost hysterical. In one hand she held a blood-soaked towel, and in the other she held a mirror.

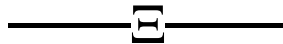
* * * *

Emily sipped a glass of tequila as she sat in a bar overlooking a beach in Mexico, comfortable and cool in a pale blue vest top and a pair of

cut-off jeans. Her travelling companion was in a short skirt and white bikini top, her blonde hair pulled back in a pony tail. A lot of the men in the bar were sneaking glances at the pair of them.

Two men walked into the bar and ordered beers. They were both tall and tanned, and spoke with Australian accents. The men saw the girls and made their way towards their table. Emily saw Philippa push out her breasts, and she smiled to herself. Some things never change.

THE END



[Delores Swallows](#)

United Kingdom (2015)

About the Author



Delores Swallows has many dirty thoughts, and during his free time he writes them down in the form of stories. Born and bred in the northwest of England, he has a commoner's accent and a bit of a crush on his future queen (Kate, not Camilla!).

His stories often feature petite brunettes, high-heeled shoes and voyeurism. He claims he didn't realise these were obsessions until someone pointed out how often they appear in his work.

Find out more about Delores on his [web site](#), chat on [Twitter](#), or follow his new stories on [Amazon](#). And don't forget to sign up to his [mailing list](#) for a **free story**.

Don't forget your dirty story exclusively available to members of [Delores' mailing list](#).

Also by Delores Swallows



The Ménage Diaries

I woke as Gemma slipped into bed beside me, her bare leg rubbing against mine. There's nothing like waking up to a soft, warm body after five solitary nights in a cab, and my dick was hard before she'd slid her hand under the quilt.

"Mmm," she said as she wrapped her fingers around me. "What've you been dreaming about?"

I eased her onto her back and slipped inside, hearing her sigh as my cock slid all the way home. She often told me mine was the biggest she'd ever had, but I assume she was trying to stroke my ego. I reckon if it was that big, my ex-wife wouldn't have been so eager to sample quite so many others.

"Ah, that feels good," Gemma whispered as I started to fuck her with long, slow thrusts. "That's just so..."

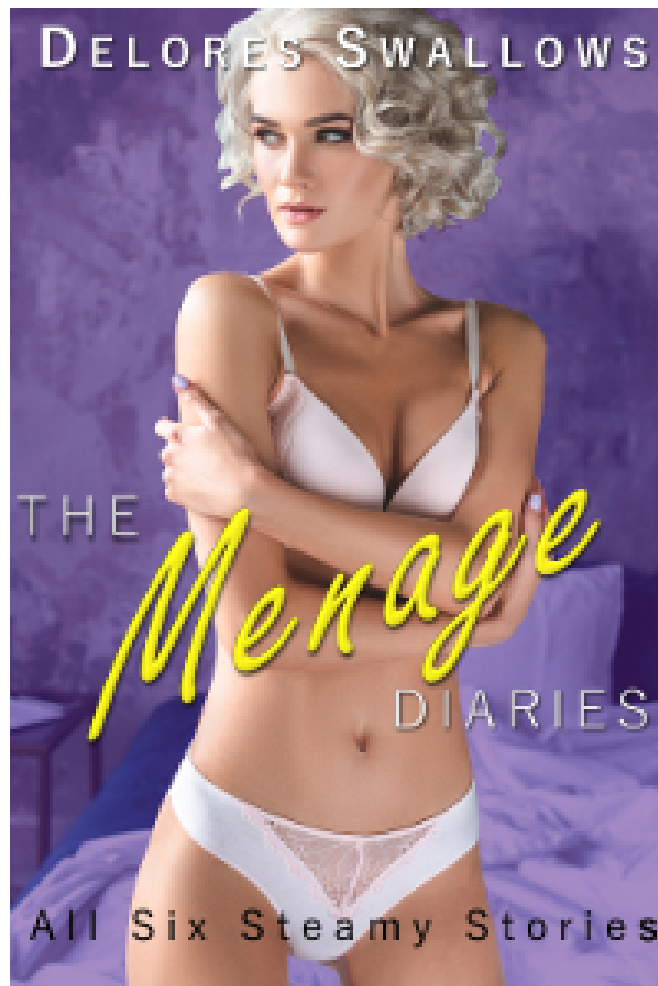
I sped up a little, revelling in the softness of the mattress and her tits, the smoothness of the sheets and her legs. The snugness of her bed and her cunt.

"Oh, Jon."

When she came, her nails raked my back and her inner muscles gripped my dick. I ploughed on through her contractions, feeling her wetness dribbling onto my balls. Her nails dug into me again, and it hurt. I pinned her arms above her head and held myself up as I pounded her, watching her tits shake from the force of my thrusts. Her eyelids fluttered and she let out muted little whimpers.

With a final lunge, I buried myself as deep as I could and unloaded, flooding her. She let out encouraging moans as she wriggled beneath me, and I finally dropped on top of her, satiated. This was the best way to start the weekend.

[Taken from: The Lodger]



The complete collection — all six steamy ménage stories.

Taking the Plunge: When Nick asks Molly about her ultimate sexual fantasy, she reveals it's a threesome with two men in a hot tub. Though shocked, the more Nick thinks about sharing his wife, the more turned on he

gets. The idea of watching her with another man becomes an obsession, but it turns out that Molly's only too happy to make her fantasy a reality—going as far as booking a chalet in the Swiss Alps with its own private hot tub.

The only question now is who Molly will choose to join them...

1999: *As her husband of twelve years has run off with another woman, Mindy faces the new millennium needing a new home and new job. But before facing her daunting future head-on, she decides to celebrate the upcoming special Hogmanay in style. In a posh Edinburgh hotel, she puts on her best dress and happy face, deciding that tonight's the perfect night to take a man back to her room for a night of no-strings passion—something she hasn't done since her punk rock days.*

Her night starts promisingly when she shares her table with two hunky brothers—complete with kilts—but when that spell is broken, a different offer presents itself in the form of a beautiful Scottish woman and her handsome Scandinavian husband.

It's something she's never considered before, but... New millennium, new Mindy.

Victor-Juliet-Charlie: *When police raid a large house in an exclusive London suburb expecting to find women forced into the sex trade by human traffickers, all they find are very attractive young women reaping the benefits of being the playthings of older Russian oligarchs. While most of the officers consider their evening wasted, Lynne, a WPC, sees things differently. Having witnessed a young blonde woman tied to a bed being used by two men, she finds herself both excited and painfully aware that her own life isn't as exciting as it should be.*

As the raiders 'debrief' over a few drinks at the pub, Lynne confesses to Joey, an old friend and ex-lover, how much the experience had affected her. And when a young, handsome PC joins their conversation, she realises that this may be the perfect opportunity for her to have a little fun of her own...

The Lodger: *Trucker Jon has a good thing going. He might spend the week in his cramped cab, but his weekends are spent in the warm comfort of*

Gemma's bed. Life couldn't be better—until Gemma announces that she's taking in a lodger.

He's worried at first that their blissful routine may be disturbed, but it turns out that drama queen Amy happens to be a blonde stunner with a body to die for.

When Gemma confides that her attempts to comfort Amy went a little far one night, her previous indiscretions come to light, too. Jon gets the impression that his lovely girlfriend is giving him carte blanche to sleep with the flirtatious lodger to even up the scores.

Jon knows that only the most unscrupulous of men would accept such an offer, but who's he to deny Gemma her absolution? Besides, the lodger is so incredibly hot...

Julia 07: *Julia receives an invitation to attend a Retirement Ball for her ex-lecturer and decides to attend, even though she won't know any of the other attendees. Once there, she meets two charming young men who both vie for her affections, each trying to persuade her to choose him over the other. But as the night progresses, she realises her choice doesn't have to be a simple either-or decision.*

Later that evening, after doing something she'd never have believed herself capable of, Julia realises she hadn't made the most of the situation. This may be a once-in-a-lifetime opportunity to lose herself in the ecstasy of surrendering herself to two men at the same time.

Could she live with herself if she did it? Then again, could she ever forgive herself if she didn't...?

Party Crasher: *Emma's delighted when her housemate tells her that sexy postgrad-come-barman Jamie is hoping to run into her at an upcoming student party. She's hoping he'll be more mature than the undergrads she's dated so far.*

When they meet again, Jamie's just as cute, charming and funny as she remembers. She knows that before long, they'll be doing a whole lot more than just flirting.

Then Pru crashes the party. Blonde, gorgeous and confident, she's every rival's nightmare.

Emma's unwilling to give Jamie up without a fight, but she's not prepared for Pru to be such good company. She's certainly not expecting to find another girl attractive.

Yet as the night progresses with a move to Jamie's place, it turns out that Pru isn't the party crasher after all...

[The Ménage Diaries](#) is available from Amazon



Web of Deceit

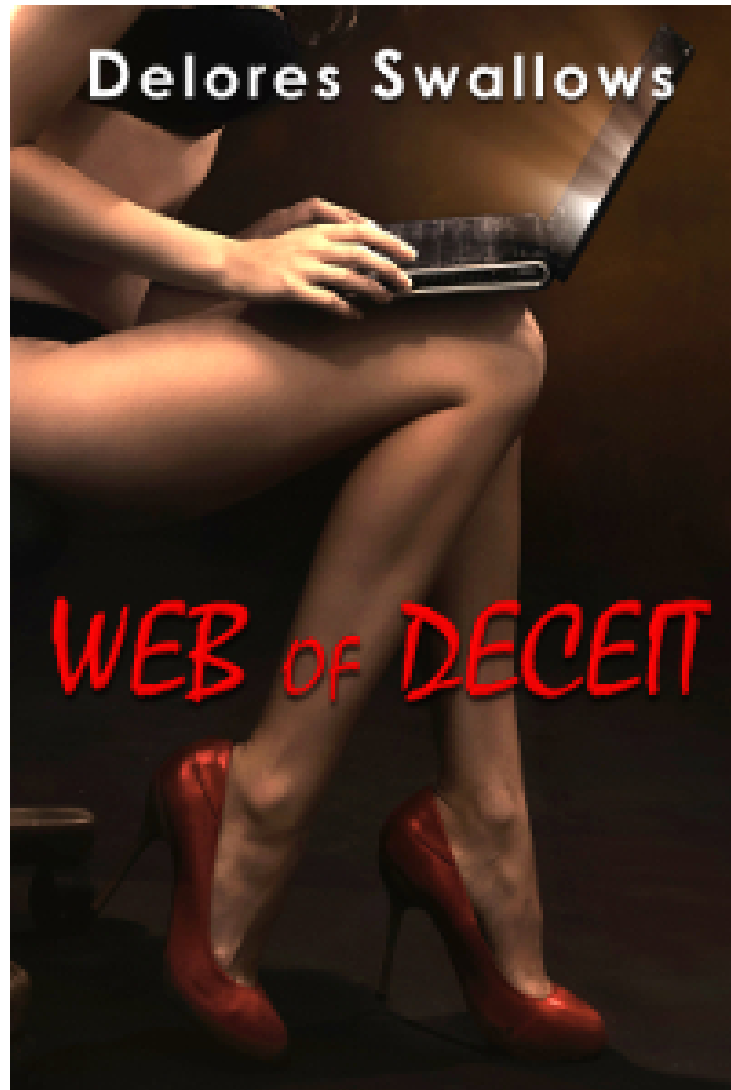
I'm in Germany on business, attending a conference. While in the hotel spa, during a free afternoon, I meet a German couple who are on holiday. They're mid-thirties and both attractive—particularly the woman, who has a great figure. We chat while in the hot tub, and when they discover I'm staying on my own they invite me to join them for dinner that evening.

After a very pleasant meal we adjourn to the bar for a few drinks, and then we all go back to their room. I know I'm about to have a threesome, as the conversation throughout the meal had been filled with innuendo. Once in their room the lights are turned down low and we all stand by the bed. There's a lot of touching – mainly them touching me, but I also touch them. They slowly undress me, and I help them to lose their clothes, too. When we're all naked we move onto the bed. I'm lying on my side in the middle, with the guy behind me, almost lying 'spoons'. His wife lies on her side facing me, and she kisses me on the mouth and then strokes

and kisses my boobs. Her husband is stroking me down my side, across my hip and down my legs. I'm pushed back a little so I'm almost on my back, with the guy beneath me. His hands are running all over my boobs and stomach, and his wife is kissing all around my bush and inner thighs.

As I look down I see her head is moving backwards and forwards. I move my leg to get a better view and see she's sucking her husband's cock. I briefly feel like I'm surplus to requirements, but then she takes it out of her mouth and puts it at the opening of my slit. I realise she was just getting him hard enough to enter me, which he does. He slides all the way inside me from behind, pulling my hips down with his hands. Then his wife starts to lick and suck my clit, and he starts to fuck me slowly. I come almost straight away. I'm practically screaming, and he keeps fucking me and she keeps licking me. I come again. I'm pulling her hair and scratching his legs and panting like a dog.

I'm lying very still in the afterglow, waiting for my heart to stop racing and my breathing to get back to normal, and I feel him move slightly inside me. I realise I'm the only participant that's had an orgasm—well, two. I somehow manage to lift myself off him, and tell her to lie where I'd been. I want her to feel what I'd just felt. So as she lies back onto her husband, I guide his wet, slippery cock into her cunt. Then I bend forward and taste another woman for the first time ever. I lick and suck her clit as he starts to fuck her, and then I feel his dick bang against my chin. He'd obviously pulled it too far out. I hold his dick in my hand and take it as far into my mouth as I can manage. I run my tongue around the tip and I hear him moan. I slip it back inside his wife and get back to licking her and she's pulling my head against her. I can tell she's about to come. I rub his balls and then rest my fingers against the shaft of his dick. With each thrust my fingers are going inside her, and she's screaming almost as loud as I did. I decide I should help her husband along, so I drop my mouth from her clit onto his balls. I take one onto my mouth and suck it, and then do the same to the other. I can hear him grunting. Finally I press my tongue against the base of his shaft, and as he comes I can feel each spurt that he pumps into his wife.



What starts as a light-hearted flirtation with a stranger in a chatroom soon becomes an obsession for Chloe. Her on-line discussions quickly progress from innocuous revelations about previous partners to her most intimate fantasies. As she's becoming fixated with exploring different ways of giving and receiving pleasure, her partner Damien gets caught in the cross-fire. Meanwhile, Damien finds himself being used to satisfy her sexual appetite, so why does he feel so guilty?

In the anonymous world of cyber-sex and cheating, it's hard to tell exactly who is being deceived.

And what happens when the fantasy isn't enough?

[Web of Deceit](#) is available from Amazon



Midnight Mirror

For the next few nights Natalie avoided any chance of a recurrence of the visions in the mirror by making sure she was in bed well before midnight. She was constantly on edge—barely sleeping—but finally decided she couldn't allow a piece of furniture to implement a curfew in her own home. She convinced herself she had to confront the mirror again.

She faced the mirror at midnight in her pyjamas.

As expected, the room temperature dropped suddenly, and her reflection's blinking began. The reflected-image fell away and this version of herself had long, straight blonde hair and a fringe, her make-up bold—red lipstick, thick eye-liner and mascara. She wore a white mini-dress and white, shiny, plastic knee-length boots. The room was fairly small, furnished with hard-backed chairs facing wall-mounted mirrors. A lot of guitars leant up against those walls.

Natalie's heart raced along with the girl's as she connected with her reflection's train of thought and feelings. The blonde was a groupie from the 60's who'd managed to get backstage and access to the band's dressing room. Suddenly, the door opened and two men walked in. One was about six feet tall, the other a little shorter but broader across the chest. They were

wearing the dark grey suits which the band wore on stage, but they were also wearing clown masks. Natalie stared at the surreal image and though a little disturbed, she was simultaneously excited. Her rock-chick counterpart saw the masks as an added piece of intrigue. She was going to have sex with two members of her favourite band, but she'd never know which ones they were.

The men approached.

Natalie saw the reflected girl smiling shyly, fluttering her heavily-mascaraed lashes.

The taller man put his hand on her shoulders and encouraged her to get down on her knees, which she did. He undid the buttons of his trousers, presenting her with his semi-erect cock.

Natalie watched her sixties-self look up into his face and open her mouth. As the guy pushed in, Natalie felt a chill slide over her tongue. A tap on the side of her head drew her eyes to the second man, who'd got his cock out, touching it against the groupie's face. She watched as her other self released the first cock and greedily took in the second. This cock was much harder, and as the stocky man pushed his hips forward, Natalie gagged as a phantom cock hit the back of her throat.

The taller guy walked round behind the girl, pushing her down until she was on all-fours and rolling her knickers down her thighs. The shorter man dropped to his knees so she could still reach his cock with her mouth. Natalie could still feel the presence of the hard cock in her mouth when the sensation of being entered hit her. She watched as the girl pushed herself back onto the first man, all the while using her mouth on the second. The two men swapped places and again Natalie shared the feeling of being entered and fucked.

She could taste her own juices when the other cock pushed into her mouth. Her panties became wet as the girl was fucked hard by the stockier man. Then the mirror trio changed positions. The taller guy lay on his back on the floor, and 60's Natalie lay on top, using her hand to guide his cock inside her. The other man lowered himself into position and entered her anally.

Natalie let out a yelp as the second cock pushed in, giving her a sensation of fullness she'd never had before. As the mirror figures writhed on the floor, Natalie was in some discomfort, but also experiencing a lot of pleasure. She found herself moving her body in time with them, in shock, but unable to stop herself from responding to the cool, hard double-penetration. She breathed heavily, moaning with every push of their hips. The men increased the force of their thrusts—one above, one below—and a surge washed through Natalie as she and the girl in the mirror both came. Natalie cried out loud, and the lack of sound did nothing to diminish the ecstasy of the girl on the other side of the mirror. Natalie watched as the men banged harder and then held still. Iciness flooded her insides, both front and back.

She closed her eyes, focussing her feelings, knowing she was going to come again. Holding on to the mantelpiece for support, she contracted and relaxed her muscles around the phantom cocks still invading her and tumbled into a second wave of pleasure. Her breath was ragged when she finally opened her eyes and looked back into the mirror.

She'd expected to see her own reflection, so was a little surprised to look back up at the dressing room scene. The men stood up, their backs turned to Natalie, and looked down at the groupie who was still sitting on the floor, smiling up at them as their juices ran out of her. Natalie could feel the cold seep in her crotch and inner thighs. As the men removed their clown masks, the smile on the girl's face turned to shock, then distress. She held her hand over her mouth and let out a scream that Natalie felt like a slap inside her head.

The men turned round and looked at Natalie, making her gasp and take a step back. Never before had the people in the mirror shown any indication that they knew they were being watched. The men weren't band members, but imposters who'd bought similar suits. Their badly disfigured faces couldn't conceal that, beneath the scars, they were a lot older than the girl or the band members—perhaps in their forties or fifties. As they looked directly at Natalie, they smiled without a trace of humour. When their eyes started the high-speed blink, she turned and ran into her bedroom.

She got very little sleep that night.



To brighten her dreary flat, Natalie buys an old mirror, soon finding that it isn't what it seems. At the witching hour, her reflection takes on a life of its own. Natalie finds herself physically sharing the sex scenes taking place inside the glass.

Her mirror is her hot little secret until the scenes on the other side become disturbing, making her frightened to stay in her own home.

She knows she needs to overcome the force behind the glass, but the only thing she can think of is to use herself as bait...

[Midnight Mirror](#) is available from Amazon

